

Elite Persistence in the Era of England's Expanding Overseas Trade

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Abstract

This paper considers the consequences of England's 17th-century dramatic expansion of overseas trade for the persistence and turnover of political elites. I study the extent to which “new” commercial economic interests—individuals involved in expanding trade—obtained Parliamentary representation, as well as the extent to which those individuals were connected to members of the incumbent parliamentary elite or hereditary aristocracy. I do so using an original dataset on Members of Parliament (MPs) spanning more than two centuries (~1550-1750). Despite the dramatic expansion of trade during the period, I find that only a modest share of Parliament represented the commercial sector, and overseas traders never constituted a majority of commercial representatives. The parliamentary entrée of trading interests manifested most acutely via investors in trade rather than active participants. Moreover, the growing Atlantic economy was associated with little turnover in MPs' social and family backgrounds. Broadly, I find that elites persisted across the economic changes of the long 17th century and were well-positioned to capture many of the early gains for themselves.

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“The discovery of America, and that of passage to the East Indies by the Cape of Good Hope, are the two Greatest and most important events recorded in the history of mankind.”

The Wealth of Nations (1776)
ADAM SMITH

The rise of the Atlantic economy in the early modern period is often considered one of the most important historical moments in the economic and political development of Europe (Pomeranz, 2001; Zwart and Zanden, 2018). The discovery and subsequent adoption of new overseas trade routes between Europe, Africa, Asia, and the Americas arguably set Europe on a divergent path from the rest of the world and set Western Europe, specifically, on a divergent path from its southern and eastern cousins (Acemoglu, Johnson and Robinson, 2005).

Amongst Western European cases, England is typically upheld as the paragon of this development path. In explaining England’s trajectory, scholars emphasize a myriad of specific factors, but the dominant explanations in the literature have all centered in some way on the interplay between the growing power of commercial interests and the institutions that allowed those interests to exercise political power (Acemoglu, Johnson and Robinson, 2005; Moore, 1966; North and Weingast, 1989; Brenner, 2003; Stasavage, 2003; Cox, 2016). At the same time, a systematic examination of how and to what extent political institutions came to represent merchants throughout the period of England’s expanding trade remains missing from the literature.

This paper considers the rise in the descriptive representational power of commerce in the context of England during the long 17th century. I ask about the extent to which the seemingly disruptive changes of expanding overseas trade did or did not generate turnover in the political elite. To date, the literature offers competing explanations both for why economic change should produce elite turnover and also for why existing elites should be expected to persist. On the one hand, we tend to think of economic transformations as highly disruptive to a political-economic equilibrium (Schumpeter, 1942; Boix, 2015; Dasgupta, 2018; Fresh, 2024). Economic change is a process of creative *destruction*, Schumpeter describes;

one that sees hidebound elements of the economy swept aside in favor of the nouveau. Though his argument is made for the post-industrial era, we might still expect the same destructive forces to obtain as England’s 17th-century infant capitalism crawled forward from the medieval economy.

At the same time, there is good reason to think that even large economic transformations may not result in commensurate political upheavals. The political economy literature is replete with accounts of elites persisting across seemingly disruptive events (see, e.g., Berlinski, Dewan and Coppenolle (2014), Martinez-Bravo, Mukherjee and Stegmann (2017), Albertus and Menaldo (2018), Bellani, Hager and Maurer (2022)). In the context of economic change, extant political elites are often those with substantial control over the economy, as well as those best positioned to, alternatively, block economic change or capture the benefits for themselves, and then to persist in political power (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2006*a*). These questions of persistence, capture, and turnover matter both for our ability to *understand* and *explain* change (Elster, 1989), but also because elites from different backgrounds carry with them other identities, traits, and preferences that may both shape their behavior within institutions (Stasavage, 2003) and condition perceptions about the legitimacy of the institutions themselves (Lipset, 1960).

Because of these competing theoretical expectations, this paper contends that a comprehensive explanation of how representation changed in response to the Atlantic economy requires an understanding of both the rise of commercial interests to political power, *and* an understanding of the extent to which those interests constituted fundamentally new individuals, families and groups in society. Absent an understanding of both dimensions of potential persistence—what I term the *economic* dimension and the *socio-familial* dimension—it’s difficult to know whether the previous elite may have actually benefited from change, directed it, and ultimately persisted in power under a potentially new economic guise. Conceptualizing and measuring change on both dimensions is, therefore, a necessary first step to understanding questions of persistence and turnover.

To that end, I present a simple analytic typology that lays out the ways in which the

composition of the political elite in England's Parliament may have been impacted by the economic changes of England's long 17th century along each of the two dimensions. Then, to measure these dimensions of the political elite, I assemble a new dataset of more than two hundred years of detailed representational history of the near universe of Members of Parliament (MPs) who served in the House of Commons (~ 1550 -1750). Using natural language processing on the narrative biographies, in combination with data on indirect involvement in overseas trade via company investments, I am able to code the individual economic interests of MPs, measure surname connections to account for the entrance of new families to politics, and observe MP relationships to traditional sources of social and political power, namely the hereditary aristocracy. Both the temporal breadth and individual detail of this data represent a significant advance in our ability to understand the dynamics of elite persistence and turnover over the centuries-long scale during which economic change unfolds, a significant motivation for the case selection.

With this data, I demonstrate that commercial interests increased their representation in parliament as trade expanded. But despite the scale of overseas trade, this entr   was highly circumscribed in occupational terms. Mercantile elites—that is, MPs with occupations tied to overseas trade—never accounted for more than 10% of parliamentary representatives. However, the share of MPs with *investments* in trading companies did grow significantly in the early period of Atlantic trade prior to the Interregnum (1640-1660), peaking at around 30% of parliamentary representatives. This did not last, however, collapsing to single digits after the 1660 Restoration of the monarchy.

I further document little surname turnover in parliament, nor turnover in the extent to which MPs were connected to traditional sources of social power, namely the hereditary aristocracy (i.e., peerage). Thus, in Parliament broadly, I document a high degree of what I term *full persistence*—most of parliament over the period was comprised of existing economic interests embodied by traditional social and familial groups. When I examine the backgrounds of MPs with trade occupations, specifically, I find that while some of these were truly “new” elites in the sense of representing new surnames to politics and lacking aristocratic connections, a large portion were nevertheless drawn from existing elite

families. Given that, I argue that amongst representatives of the Atlantic economy, elites can best be characterized as displaying *captured economic change*. New economic activities found some descriptive representation in Parliament, but only because existing elites found ways to co-opt the ongoing economic transformation—that is, a way to participate to their benefit.

Within these more general trends, I find patterns that indicate that the nature of elite turnover was subtly conditioned by the political nature of different periods of trade expansion. Prior to the English Civil War, when the nature of trade in both of the two new geographic spheres of international trade—eastward to Asia versus westward to the Americas—facilitated monopoly trading protections, existing elites managed to capture a larger share of the gains from trade through investments in trading companies. When the nature of westward trade changed following the Restoration—monopoly protection no longer being widely tenable—the representation of MPs who either held investments in New World trading companies or had occupations related to New World trading fell much more than the representation of MPs with ties to Asian trade. Of course, given that parliamentary elites were both producers *of* institutional change, as well as affected *by* them, these patterns constitute descriptive insights, not causal estimates of the “effect” of these economic and policy changes.

These findings build on a number of important studies that have considered commercial interests in England’s early modern period. First, they build on Hillmann (2008) and Jha (2015), who identify a critical role of mercantile interests in the 1640 Long Parliament’s defection against the Crown which began the English Civil War. While those studies consider only a single, albeit important, parliament, here I expand the scope of inquiry to two hundred years of representational history, covering the entire rise of the Atlantic economy. Other work, such as Stasavage (2003), shows that mercantile MPs held very few seats following the Glorious Revolution, raising questions about the independent importance of commercial interests (absent cross-cutting cleavages). By extending the study back to the mid-16th century, I demonstrate that this representative pattern was not merely an artifact of the 18th-century era of Whig supremacy.

This paper corroborates the conclusion of (Erikson, 2021) that the rise of merchants to parliament over the long 17th century was modest. However, it also expands the analysis of persistence to include the socio and familial backgrounds of MPs with commercial interests, examining *investment* in overseas trade in addition to direct occupational involvement, and by studying differences across geographic spheres of trade. The paper’s results provide a detailed demonstration of claims by scholars such as Clark (2014) that the socio-familial elite composition of parliament was highly stable even through periods of apparent tumult. And finally, my work compliments Brenner (2003)’s classic work on London’s merchant elite leading up to, and during the Interregnum by expanding the focus from London to all of England.

Finally, this paper contributes broadly to the study of historical persistence. The quantitative study of the long-run *effects* of historical factors—trade being particularly relevant in the context of this study (Jha, 2013; Gaikwad, 2014)—has grown substantially in recent years. Yet, studies that systematically analyze the historical *evolution* of political and economic change, particularly at the meso and micro-scale, are far rarer. But an understanding of this persistence *process*, with its attendant mechanisms, is increasingly called for in this literature (Abad and Maurer, 2021; Cirone and Pepinsky, 2022). Understanding these descriptive dynamics is a key but neglected first step to answering questions about how persistence functions and what might—or might not—disrupt it (Nunn, 2009). The framework and the findings in this paper suggest that seemingly disruptive economic change may not straightforwardly remake the political class.

1 Understanding Elite Persistence and Turnover: An Analytic Typology

To aid my empirical investigation of the relationship between economic and political power during this period, it helps to first establish a clear analytic typology of what we mean by elite persistence (or turnover). I argue there are two important and distinct dimensions upon which we should consider elite persistence: *i)* the relationship a given set of political

representatives has to the emergent sector(s) of the economy (*new economic interests*), as opposed to traditional sector(s) of the economy (*old economic interests*); and *ii*) the relationship a given set of political representatives has to the incumbent political elite via their own incumbency, their family relationships, or their social class (*old political families*), as compared to representing fundamentally new individuals, families and social groups in society (*new political families*). Characterizing persistence and turnover on these two dimensions allows for a comprehensive evaluation of the extent to which political power and economic power are linked and the conditions under which they can be de-coupled. Insofar as persistence is assumed to be a first-best option for incumbent political elites, the manner in which elites persist is a necessary first step to theorizing the conditions under which alternative strategies to persistence are employed—e.g., hollowing out the state (Suryanarayan and White, 2021), entrepreneurship in ideas (Erikson, 2021), or investments in coercive capacity (Eubank and Fresh, 2022).

In contexts of observed economic change (as in c.17th century England), the literature’s interest in the economic dimension of turnover is well-established. Economic interests typically correspond to distinct policy preferences, which in turn produce economic outcomes the literature cares about (e.g., Mares and Queralt (2015), Beramendi, Dincecco and Rogers (2019)). Yet, beyond the economic interest dimension, it’s also possible to observe changes in the social and family relationships political representatives have to those from an earlier period—i.e., those who served in a previous Parliament. This socio-familial relationship to prior political power may too matter for policy outcomes because of how policy preferences are organized across social groups, and because of how political power *itself* may shape interests (e.g., Michels (1966), Albertus and Menaldo (2018), Martinez-Bravo, Mukherjee and Stegmann (2017)). Class and family dimensions may be important in shaping potentially cross-cutting cleavages (Stasavage, 2003). And because the value of turnover may comprise an important normative dimension, the extent to which new individuals, families, and social classes enter politics may shape perceptions of the legitimacy of institutions (Lipset, 1960).

Along this socio-familial dimension of persistence, representatives *themselves* may be in-

Table 1: Types of elite persistence and turnover given who is observed in political power after economic change

		<i>Socio-Familial</i>	
		Old Political Families	New Families
<i>Economic</i>	Old Economic Interests	Full Persistence	Social Circulation
	New Economic Interests	Captured Economic Turnover	Full Turnover

cumbents who held a seat in a previous Parliament. Alternatively, a given set of representatives may have a *family* connection to the political elite in a previous period (a political dynasty) (Adams, 2005; Querubin, 2016). Finally, this connection to an incumbent elite may come in the form of a broader *social class* (e.g., the hereditary aristocracy) that is not merely coincident with (i.e., reducible to) a particular economic interest.¹

These two dimensions of representational persistence or turnover need not move hand in hand. For example, where economic change is *co-opted* by the incumbent political elite, we may observe changes in the economic interests of political representatives. Here, co-optation refers to the process by which incumbent political elites come to benefit from new economic activities. They may participate indirectly (e.g., invest in financial instruments), and/or participate directly (e.g., diversify their time and resources into new activities). Yet, the *people* embodying these new economic interests may come from established political families or extant class groups, with no change in social-familial representation.

Four types of persistence and turnover derive from these two dimensions of representational change (Table 1). First, a political representative may display *full persistence*, where there is no change in the economic interest they embody nor their socio-familial background. Incumbent economic *and* political power remain linked in the face of a changing economy. Second, a representative may display *full turnover* if they are part of a new economic group who enters politics *and* a new social or family background. Third, a representative may demonstrate *captured economic turnover*, where they represent a new economic interest, but they are also from an incumbent political family that has transitioned their activities to

¹Of course, the nature of class in different contexts will condition the extent to which these dimensions are or are not coincident.

the emergent sectors of the economy, thereby “capturing” change for their benefit. Finally, if somehow old economic interests remain in political power but are represented by new groups who didn’t formerly hold political power, then we might observe *social circulation*.²

Only under rare circumstances are we likely to observe the *pure* reflection of a single type within an institution as a whole. Instead, these types apply to individual members of the political elite, reflecting extant individual-level economic and socio-familial power. Therefore, when aggregated to the institutional level, continuity and disruption must be conceived in terms of domination and degree—i.e., *which* type dominates the combined members of the institution, as well as *how much* it dominates.³

2 The Rise of the Atlantic Economy in England

I apply this typology to England during the long 17th century, which saw the rise of new Atlantic trade. In this section, I detail some of the key characteristics of this expansion from the perspective of the English political elite to both form expectations about how persistence unfolded and offer an interpretive frame for the subsequent quantitative results.

Critically, the expansion of c.17th century overseas trade was not monolithic. Rather, it is best understood as having encompassed *i)* two distinct geographic spheres, and *ii)* two distinct temporal eras. As I describe below, where the eastward overseas trades to Asia tended to privilege an existing merchant elite, the westward trades required skills—amongst those *actively* involved (i.e., holding occupations tied to westward trade)—distinct from those of pre-existing trading activities. Early trade before the English Civil War (pre-1640) tended to favor the incumbent political elite via monarchy-granted monopolies, which restricted the entry of merchants themselves but often allowed non-merchants to invest. By contrast, the post-Restoration period (post-1660) saw the de-regulation of trade via

²Though this outcome seems decidedly less plausible.

³As is common when applying a binary typology to a continuous metric, the binary typology helps to frame the ideal types of the comparison, but it can only do so much. Thus, *when*, precisely, one wishes to claim generalized persistence (at the institutional level) versus generalized turnover is an interpretive choice. In practice, the application of the binary labels of “persistence” and “turnover” are likely to be meaningful in terms of *i)* comparison to a prior or later period within the same context, *ii)* comparison to those same measures made for another (arguably relevant) case, or *iii)* comparison made to ex-ante priors or predictions.

Parliamentary control of monopoly grants, in theory opening trade more to new groups.

The Origins of Overseas Trade

Although the emphasis in this paper is on the period of rapidly expanding Atlantic trade, it's essential to ground that discussion in a recognition of the significant role international trade played in England's economy for centuries prior to the 1500s. In the late 1400s, technological improvements in navigation and shipbuilding were deployed by England's fierce rivals—Spain, Portugal, and later the Dutch—to establish sea routes to Asia and the Americas.⁴ In the competitive early modern European state system, failure to reap the economic benefits of expanding trade constituted an existential threat (Hoffman, 2015).⁵ In response to the advances of its rivals, England produced voyages of “discovery” from the 1550s—by 1601, it had established trade to South Asia around the Cape of Good Hope. By the 1620s, it had established colonies in North America and the Caribbean. As Brenner (1972) writes, the expansion of trade in the late 16th century “mark[ed] an important break” in the trade England had experienced up to that point.

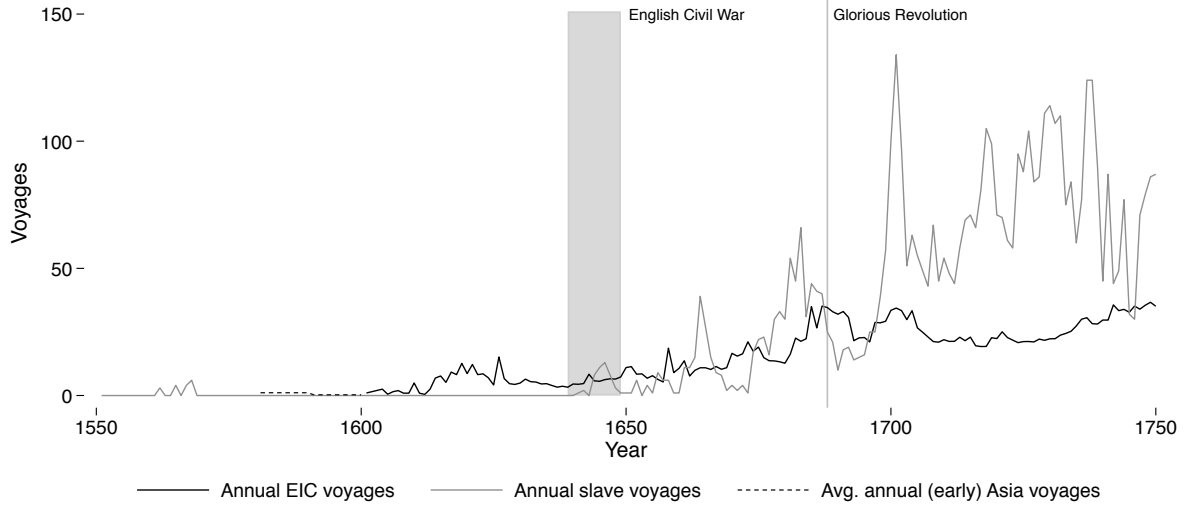
Figure 1 documents one way of conceiving of this “break” in trade: the growth of voyages in two key trades of the new Atlantic economy—English East India Company (E.I.C.) voyages and English-flagged slave voyages to the Americas.⁶ The growth in these voyages is indicative of broader changes in the economy that derived from them—for example, imports into London alone doubled between 1600 and 1630; and over the two centuries 1550-1750, economic output deriving from trade grew tenfold (Broadberry et al., 2015). Grassby (1970) documents that the net personal estates of London merchants above £500 grew from 27% before 1614, to 38% after the Restoration, to 42% by 1700. Additional trends that demonstrate the growth in Atlantic trade are presented in Appendix A. However, it's

⁴See Zwart and Zanden (2018) and Rapp (1975) for discussions of what changed beyond technology. Acemoglu, Johnson and Robinson (2005) also emphasize the importance of geography and executive constraints.

⁵Contemporaneous debates about commerce deeply concerned its role in international power struggles (Pincus, 1998).

⁶I select these trends because they capture new trades of the Atlantic economy—as opposed to other measures that might capture trade, *generally*—and because they are available at a fine-grained level throughout the period of study. Other measures, such as duties on particular commodities or imports by commodity type (that would reveal Atlantic-specific trade), are inconsistently available.

Figure 1: Trends in long-distance Atlantic trading voyages, 1550-1750



Sources: Slave voyages are calculated from Eltis et al. (2016); E.I.C. voyages are calculated from Sutton (1981); early voyages to Asia are calculated from Vries (2003).

Notes: The above plot shows two trends in English overseas voyages: (1) annual slave voyages by English-flagged ships, (2) annual E.I.C. voyages, and (3) average annual early voyages to Asia (pre-E.I.C.) via the Cape of Good Hope. The quantity of trading across geographic spheres is not directly comparable since each series accounts for a different share in overall trade within the sphere. For reference, the English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and a gray vertical line at 1688 indicates the Glorious Revolution.

important to note that while these trends demonstrate comparable timing in the break, the magnitudes are not directly comparable since each captures distinct shares of trading in a given geographic sphere.

The English Crown was a key driver of many of these early attempts to establish a robust Atlantic trade via state-financed voyages and Crown-chartered monopoly trading ventures.⁷ The Crown supplied monopoly protection to induce participation and to share in the spoils of trade—which could be substantial—at a time in the late 16th and early 17th centuries when it struggled to finance itself via other means (Ashton, 1960). Early overseas trading routes also exhibited natural barriers to entry, requiring large initial outlays to fund a voyage and involved substantial risk (Clay, 1984).⁸ The possibility that later entrants might compete away rents and negate upfront investments led many venturers to demand monopoly protection (Rabb, 1967; Griffiths, 1974).

⁷Some scholars, going back to Fisher (1940), have argued that the mid-16th century depression in the Low Countries spurred individual traders to seek new export markets. This was certainly true to an extent. Yet, by and large, English trade from the mid-16th to the late 18th centuries was driven by domestic demand for foreign products (Fisher, 1976; Price, 1989; Brenner, 2003). Export-led trade materialized much later, towards the mid-18th century (Ramsay, 1957).

⁸Credit became an increasingly important aspect of trade, but merchants still needed collateral and reputation (Price, 1989).

The Two Geographic Spheres of Trade

Although eastward and westward trades were born in large part via monopoly protection in an age of intense interstate competition, scholars have noted that they exhibited important distinctions in their economic organization and in turn, their social organization.⁹

Asia Trade. Eastward trade to the Middle East and Asia established sea routes to products that were known to be lucrative, as they had previously traveled to England via other routes (Davis, 1973). Trade was facilitated by substantial specie to buy the goods and by social networks between English merchants and their in-country trading partners (Chaudhri, 1965; Brenner, 1972). Powerful eastern trading competitors (Dutch, Portuguese) necessitated English ventures to develop costly military capacity, and monopoly helped to curtail free riding (Bogart, 2016). This Asian trade was broadly complimentary to the assets—social connections and specialized skills—of an existing overseas mercantile elite (Rabb, 1967; Smith, 2021).¹⁰ As a consequence, “in social background and position” observes Brenner (1972), “they did not differ substantially from other leading City merchants... [and so] this fundamental commercial disjuncture was paralleled by no real break in social development,” to the significant envy of those interested in joining the trade.¹¹

These elite merchant backgrounds, in turn, facilitated the erection of substantial rent-preserving entry barriers via Crown monopoly.¹² However, this did tie the success of the

⁹There were also distinctions in the religious background of merchants and investors trade geography. Brenner (2003), among others, emphasize the heavy non-Conformist orientation of traders broadly; Rabb (1967) notes the role religion played in inducing non-merchants to invest in westward trades (because it would disrupt Catholic colonial aims from rivals like Spain and provide a territory for dissenters to settle); and Stasavage (2003) identifies the importance of cross-cutting religious cleavages when merchants lacked a parliamentary majority.

¹⁰e.g., the continental cloth-trading Merchant Adventurers who had dominated pre-17th century trade with their own monopoly protection. Entry via apprenticeship further concentrated trade into trading dynasties (Grassby, 1995, 66).

¹¹Smith (2018) provides something of a counterpoint. Though initially insular, E.I.C. shareholders increased the quantity and geographic diversification of their portfolios as the 17th century progressed. Nevertheless, as Smith (2021) describes, the full extent of E.I.C. investors—large and small shareholders—was still more heavily involved in eastward and earlier continental trades. Below, I *compare* the two geographic spheres of trade, rather than describe one—albeit exceedingly important—company in one sphere of trade.

¹²The entry barriers included price-setting, limitations on shipping—including specific periods and designated vessels—and limitations on entry—e.g., long apprenticeships amongst controlled recruits. The regulated company structure was akin to a guild. It admitted and trained members for their profession in trade. However, profit, loss, and financing were questions for individual traders. By contrast, joint-stock companies (which proliferated in the westward trades) provided more open investment opportunities. See,

endeavor to the whims of the Crown. In the case of the Turkey Company patentees, for example, “exceptional wealth and influence... gave them access to the highest circles of national decision-making” (Brenner, 1972). An initial “loan”—which became a gift—secured their monopoly. In the case of the E.I.C., the large sums required to purchase stock—£200—kept out most non-merchants.¹³ Even wealthy-enough domestic retailers were explicitly excluded, as overseas merchants were fearful of their domestic brothers’ unique ability to surreptitiously undercut cartel prices (Ekelund and Tollison, 1981). Surviving documents indicate the success of these restrictions on eastward trade. There were only a dozen or so members engaged in the Levant trade, for instance, though the trade could have supported far more (Brenner, 1972).¹⁴

American Trade. By contrast, westward trade to the Americas tended to draw its participants from new groups in society in contrast to the traditional merchant elite found in the eastward Asian trades. This distinct social organization largely reflected a distinct *economic organization* of the trade.¹⁵ Voyages to North America and the Caribbean generally failed to source traditional goods like spices and textiles. The economic value of the voyages, therefore, was initially uncertain until commodity trades in sugar and tobacco revealed their viability. Rather than complement the networks and knowledge of eastern traders, westward trade privileged an entrepreneurial group willing to take (initially) big risks in settlement, estate management, and commodity production (Zahedieh, 2010). These trades, therefore, drew a “middling sort” of smaller gentry, prosperous yeomen, and non-London commercial families—that scholars identify were likely to come from *new social groups* (Brenner, 1972). Though many of these traders had a significant physical presence in the North American colonies, the business of England’s Parliament was still exceedingly consequential to them (Zahedieh, 2010).

Where eastward trades were, in general, highly insular, even amongst those who invested,

for example, Griffiths (1974).

¹³Moreover, stock purchasing required access to the company’s Court of Committees.

¹⁴By way of comparison, the tobacco trade to the Americas supported nearly 200 traders (Brenner, 1972) (Appendix I).

¹⁵Smith (2018) goes so far as to characterize the westward trades as “non-trading” by virtue of their distinct economic organization.

the cost of participation in westward joint-stock companies was comparatively low ($\sim$ £20 as compared to £200) and drew a different group than those actively involved in the trade. Thus, the early period of American trade was open to *indirect* participants beyond the merchants themselves.¹⁶ Ultimately, the western trades proved themselves too diffuse, diverse, and unpredictable to hold together a cartel, pressuring a devolution to individual traders (Craven, 1932).¹⁷ Nevertheless, in some westward trades—e.g., sugar—that initially drew a different sort into the economic elite, economies of scale arguably pushed trade towards concentration into “fewer and larger hands” (Price, 1989, 281).

The Two Periods of Trade

The growth of the Atlantic economy in England is often characterized by two distinct periods: first, the initial period of trade up to 1640 and the outbreak of the English Civil War, and second, the period after the monarchy had been “restored” in 1660.

As Ekelund and Tollison (1981) describe, the early pre-1640 period was the “high period of mercantile monarchy” in which the Crown granted and attempted to protect numerous monopolies. One (of many) points of conflict in the 1640 English Civil War was over institutional control of commercial regulation. Powerful interests fought to keep Crown control of monopolies in order to protect their rents, while new groups pushed for competitive trade (Rabb, 1968).

At the Restoration, Parliament emerged largely victorious in this regulatory power struggle. But this generated new institutional costs to pursuing regulation because of the difficulty of building parliamentary coalitions as opposed to appeasing the singular Crown. Coupled with the increasingly widespread view—especially amongst the most prominent merchant political faction—that there were sufficient profits to be had with open (albeit *within-*

¹⁶It’s important to note that many of these early joint-stock ventures failed, bearing little return for investors. “In many cases, exclusive grants of monopoly privileges led not to the careful shifting of rents from competitors, but to abysmal economic failure” (Irwin, 1992). Though, as Rabb (1967) argues, most gentry seemed to care little of the failure—their investments were a small price to pay to be involved in “spectacular” voyages and the glory of expanding England’s empire.

¹⁷Brenner (2003) is blunt: Old corporate forms were simply “inappropriate” in western trades (93). While Stone (1972) notes that “men interested in the American trades, in New England colonization. . . were new men in new fields of entrepreneurial endeavor who chafed at the political and economic stranglehold of the older established monopolistic oligarchies” despite their initial monopolistic protection (144).

imperial England trade), there was a swift decline in westward monopolies and joint-stock companies (Ekelund and Tollison, 1981).¹⁸ Only the eastward traders, who remained largely successful under monopoly, worked hard to maintain their privileges after 1660 (Dari-Mattiacci et al., 2017).¹⁹ But they too saw many of their barriers to entry *de facto* eroded under the new political system (Griffiths, 1974).

In terms of the two geographic spheres of trade under each of the two periods, the ex-ante characterization in the literature is relatively ambiguous. Economically, what generally distinguishes these periods is the extent of uncertainty and the degree of trade consolidation. This is particularly true in the westward trades. In the American trade, early (pre-1640) forays frequently met with disaster and financial ruin. The latter period, by contrast, saw established colonies and cash crops finally begin to flourish. One possibility is that this initial success drew in later, more risk-averse traders. However, some scholars seek to characterize the latter period as one of *consolidation* as, for example, economies of scale in trades like sugar favored fewer and more powerful elites (Gauci, 2001; Zahedieh, 2010).²⁰ Such consolidation might be expected to temper the entry and turnover predicted by political de-regulation of trade.

Of course, critically, the temporal dynamics of the political representation of trade are in no way exogenous to the institutional configurations that characterize these periods. Therefore, in the subsequent sections, the characterization of elite persistence and turnover is examined descriptively.

¹⁸The Navigation Acts of 1651 (strengthened by later Restoration acts) were the classic acts of this de-regulation. They freed trade from the grip of individual trading monopolies while at the same time requiring imperial trade to pass through England on English ships.

¹⁹Though they did innovate in more efficient corporate financing.

²⁰Gauci (2001) describes the “signs of an increasingly oligarchic trend” in some westward production-trades as the 17th century waned (109). Zahedieh goes so far as to say that post-1688, rent-seeking did not disappear, but *resolved* in favor of westward trading elites. During the early Restoration period, the legitimacy of institutions claiming control of trade legislation and taxation remained contested. This “exposed [traders] to heavy competition [and] encouraged interested parties to vie for control of the institutions which could be used to manage economic activities.” The Glorious Revolution “consolidated power in the hands of Parliament and the transatlantic trading elite” (p. 44). Carruthers (1996), among others, describes how similar competition materialized within the eastward trade after the Restoration. The 1690s saw the chartering of a rival East India Company, but in the early 18th century, the competition was ultimately resolved, and the monopoly of the newly-named United East India Company consolidated.

3 Measuring Elite Persistence and Turnover

To understand whether and how economic change transformed the political elite, we need to know *who* the political elite are over the temporal scope on which trade expanded and on the two dimensions of interest—*i*) economic and *ii*) socio-family background. I conceptualize the political elite in terms of parliamentary representatives, an important governing body during the period. I build a new individual-level dataset on the economic interests, familial connections to political power, and social backgrounds of the universe of English and Welsh MPs who sat in the House of Commons from 1558-1639 and 1660-1754, which I web-scraped from online volumes of *The History of Parliament: The Commons* (henceforth: HPP). The HPP is an extensively-researched comprehensive source of biographies completed by teams of professional historians since the mid 20th century and funded by the UK parliament (since the 1990s).²¹

The Institutional Context of Representation

MPs were returned to Parliament from more than 200 urban (borough) and rural (county), generally, multi-member constituencies with varying (elite) franchises based on property and tax-paying (Thrush, 2010*a*).²² In the constituencies, there were various qualification rules for parliamentary service—e.g., being a resident freeman of a borough—although the *de facto* application of those rules was subject to the discretion of those with local power. MPs secured their seats by cultivating influence amongst the electorally relevant elites in a constituency or due to the backing of a powerful patron such as the Crown or a

²¹Appendix C describes the biographies further. The HPP data does not (yet) cover either the 1640 Short or Long Parliaments nor the Interregnum parliaments. Other sources exist for these Parliaments (e.g., Keeler (1954)), but the challenges of harmonizing the data to draw valid inferences were large relative to the value of two additional, albeit important, parliaments. It is important to note that the HPP volumes were researched and written in different periods but did not proceed linearly in historical time—i.e., the project did not begin with the parliaments of the 13th century and then move forward from there. The parliaments of the early 18th century were researched during the 1970s; the late 1500s were researched during the 1980s, while those of the early 17th century were researched during the early 2000s. More recently written biographies likely benefited from better availability of primary source material. But I note that the secular trends that I subsequently identify (e.g., aristocratic persistence) cannot be explained by the time period of biographical research. Moreover, I find effectively no correlation between commercial occupations and the time period of research ($\rho = 0.01$); nor eastward ($\rho = 0.03$) or westward occupations ($\rho = 0.05$) and the time period of research. I find a correlation of $\rho = 0.16$ between biography mentions of investment and time period of research, though I am able to use the Rabb data as an additional validation (Appendix I).

²²Due to space limitations, Appendix B describes the context further.

member of the aristocracy. Contests for seats and the notion of an electorate that exercised choice rather than assent were initially rare during this period, but increased (Hirst, 1975; Kishlansky, 1986).

Importantly, there was no Parliament-wide formal landholding qualification until 1712, and even that was not fully enforced (Habakkuk, 1990). Still, there were few members—even those whose primary occupation was in commerce—that did not own landed property of some form, both where they did business and also often in country homes (Lang, 1974). Representation and accountability were nascent concepts, and principal-agent problems bred easily with high transaction costs in acquiring information. Thus, the embodied interests (descriptive representation) of MPs were exceedingly important in determining who was returned to Parliament—whether via the selection of a patron, electorate, or elite bargain—and how MPs behaved once there (Thrush, 2010*b*).²³ As Grassby (1995) contends: “When merchants entered regional and national politics, it was to defend their particular economic interests” (p. 209).

Because of this, the measurement strategy that I employ is premised on the idea that *de jure* representation in parliament was meaningful, that embodied interests were important in shaping MP behavior in the institution, and that more embodied representation was preferred by a given interest group—though of course, this latter premise is likely bounded above by the numeric size necessary to form a politically decisive coalition.²⁴ While reasonable in the historical context, it is important to recognize that other non-representational and non-embodied means of political influence were possible (see e.g., Erikson (2021) on the value of ideas, and Peck (1993) on Court influence), and that cooperation and coordination may have been possible in ways that are not fully captured by embodied interests. In addition, though the wealthiest of active overseas merchants often found a way of conducting business from England, they did still often spend time away, thus likely at times

²³Appendix G demonstrates that commercial MPs do not appear to have had different motivations for office-seeking—e.g., status as compared to policy-making—than traditional political groups.

²⁴E.g., 50% at the upper bound for simple majority rule. Furthermore, whether the embodied representation of an investor was directly substitutable with someone actively occupied is unclear and would require further evidence to evaluate. Certainly, the personal status value of parliament—an important reason for seeking a seat (Kishlansky, 1986)—was difficult to substitute between individuals (though perhaps not impossible, with the right side payments).

precluding their ability to take up a seat in Parliament (Grassby, 1995).²⁵

The Economic Interests of MPs

I consider the economic interests of MPs both via their *i*) active involvement in commerce, and *ii*) indirect involvement via investment in overseas trading companies.

I measure active involvement in commerce using a natural language processing routine on the HPP narrative biographies. Specifically, I use an iterated modified dictionary classification in which I identify key words and phrases that indicate the economic activity of the MP, along with an extensive exclusion dictionary.²⁶ The classification routine involved: iterated random draws of sample biographies; hand-coding key inclusion and exclusion words and phrases; and validation of the word-to-interest mapping on test samples to augment the dictionaries; followed by further iteration.²⁷

I code economic interests for domestic and overseas commercial involvement, defined as direct involvement in business(es) that specialize in the distribution, purchase, or sale of goods, including merchants, wholesalers, distributors, and the retail sector, including food, lodging, etc. (e.g., Price (1989)). I refer to these as individuals with commercial occupations. I define producers separately.²⁸ I further break down international commercial

²⁵As I describe below, the commercial class is, however, broader than simply people who spent time on a ship.

²⁶I choose not to rely on the HPP survey chapters (which cover some periods) to code commercial involvement in order to produce finer-grained measures (separating eastward and westward trades, for instance) and to match my own theoretical construction of commercial to my measurement. However, I supplemented my routine with information from the HPP Appendix when available. See Appendix C.

²⁷I validate a stratified random sample of the routine's coding of economic interests by reading and hand-coding the biographies myself and comparing the routine's coding to my own ($N = 113$ non-trader MPs; $N = 34$ overseas trader MPs). In the general category of occupied merchants, I find that 100% of routine-coded commercial MPs were in fact involved in commerce according to my hand-coding. I find that 98% of MPs that the routine codes as not being involved in commerce were in fact not involved in commerce according to my hand-coding. Amongst overseas Atlantic traders, more specifically, I find that 88% of routine-coded Americas trader MPs are in fact Americas traders, and >2% of MPs that the routine codes as not being Americas traders are in fact Americas traders. (Those that the routine codes as Americas traders but which I do not are in fact somewhat ambiguous cases in which the degree of *active involvement* rather than geographic involvement is what is difficult to characterize.) I find that 92% of routine-coded Asia traders are in fact Asia traders; and 100% of those that the routine codes as not actively involved in the Asia trade are not actively involved. Finally, I find 100% of routine-coded Merchant Adventurers are in fact Merchant Adventurers; and 100% of routine-coded non-Merchant Adventurers are in fact not Merchant Adventurers.

²⁸This *non-commercial capital* (producer) category includes those involved in mining, textile production, and rare genuine service professionals like doctors (Appendix E). Scholars like Fisher (1976) are skeptical about how manufacturers benefited from trade: The key element of early (pre-1750) English trade was

involvement by region of trade: merchants involved in trade to (1) Asia and the Middle East and (2) the Americas, including the African slave trade.²⁹

To measure MPs with investments in commerce, I use the “Offices” section of HPP biographies to code memberships, directorships, and governorships of overseas trading companies. This captures equity owners, excluding investors in corporate bonds and annuities. Directors were typically required to hold large shares (Scott, 1910).³⁰ For 1558-1630, I am able to verify and augment that coding with data on ownership of overseas joint stocks from Rabb (1967).³¹ These sources are comprehensive in many ways but also limited in other important ways. The most notable of these limitations is that the Rabb data is only available in the pre-1630 period, neglecting the post-Restoration era.³²

My coding allows MPs to be involved in multiple economic activities, geographic spheres of trade, or direct as compared to indirect involvement. On average, I code MPs as engaged in 1.7 activities. For the analysis, I use an inclusive measure of interest—if an MP was *at all* engaged in commerce—as the expansion of trade may have shifted people gradually towards trade, with many still maintaining a foothold in their previous economic activity.

Appendix E considers the entrée of commercial wealth into parliament via the sons of merchants.

not “the competitive efficiency of the manufacturer... [but instead] depended on the enterprise of the merchant who scoured the world in search of desirable commodities” (209). MPs who do not fall into commercial or capital categories were generally landowners, including those who derived their income from land annuities—including lawyers and military officers.

²⁹I do not include Merchant Adventurers or other continental traders active prior to this period, instead focusing on the new trades of the Atlantic economy. In coding active involvement, I use references to the geography of trade or types of trade unique to different spheres (e.g., silk, tobacco). Appendix D.

³⁰Corporate bonds and annuities were most prominent in the case of the East India Company (E.I.C.).

³¹I code an MP as indirectly involved if *either* of the sources code the MP as involved. See Appendix D. I consider the robustness of the subsequent findings to only including the “Offices” information, excluding the Rabb data to ensure that the results are not driven by having two sources for the pre-1630 period.

³²Furthermore, the active E.I.C. transfer market c.18th century cannot be directly reflected via information from transfer books, which are lost. However, because the ledger books, which are available, record debits and credits, transfers can effectively be reconstructed by scholars (Mays and Shea, 2011, 57). However, I was unable to ascertain whether these sources were consulted by the HPP. As a consequence, the biographies may more accurately represent initial investors and large investors rather than minor investors who obtained shares on the transfer market.

The Family Backgrounds and Social Characteristics of MPs

I measure the socio-familial dimension of elite persistence in two ways: *i*) presence of common-to-politics surnames, and *ii*) family connections to the hereditary aristocracy.³³

To capture the extent to which new families entered politics, for a given MP, I identify whether their surname pre-dates them in parliament or is new relative to all former MPs.³⁴

I use birth years and numerical suffixes to distinguish between unique individuals who share first and last names. I correct last names for spelling variations and, when possible, connect matrilineal surnames through tokens of hyphenated last names.³⁵ I use data back to 1386 (England) and 1536 (Wales) to observe shared surname status even at the beginning of my period of study. I focus on new/pre-existing surnames within an entire nation (either within England or within Wales).³⁶ I interpret this measurement strategy as identifying those MPs who are *most likely* to have come from families that have never before served in parliament—even from distant relations.

While family connections, generally, were a key way in which political power was organized, such connections obtained particular importance in the context of the hereditary aristocracy, whose members had the right to sit in the House of Lords, comprising the traditional apex of English society. Peers could not maintain a concurrent seat in the Commons, but their relatives—in particular, sons—could. I code an MP as aristocratically connected if the “Family and Education” section of the biography mentions that either their father or their father-in-law held a hereditary title. I also present aristocratic measurements normalized by the size of the peerage.³⁷

³³See also Appendix E.

³⁴As distinct from social mobility measured with surnames (Clark, 2014), my measurement strategy does not trace the persistence of a stock of “initial” surnames, but dynamically allows surnames to *become* pre-existing after the first instance the surname is observed.

³⁵However, matrilineal connections will be underrepresented by virtue of naming conventions of this historical context.

³⁶In Appendix J, I further restrict potential surname connections to MPs who serve for either *i*) same constituency, *ii*) or the same county.

³⁷Appendix H documents trends in the peerage size. I exclude the hereditary but non-peerage baronetcies. One limitation of the measurement is that it does not establish when each MP’s peerage title was granted. The Stuart monarchs in the early 17th century created new hereditary peerage titles (Stone, 1965). Thus, it is possible that some aristocratically-connected MPs have such connections by virtue of a new peerage creation rather than a long lineage of social status.

4 The Composition of the Political Elite Over the Long 17th Century

Here, I describe two hundred years of how the economic interests and family backgrounds of MPs changed as the Atlantic economy grew using the data detailed in the previous section.

The Economic Interests of MPs

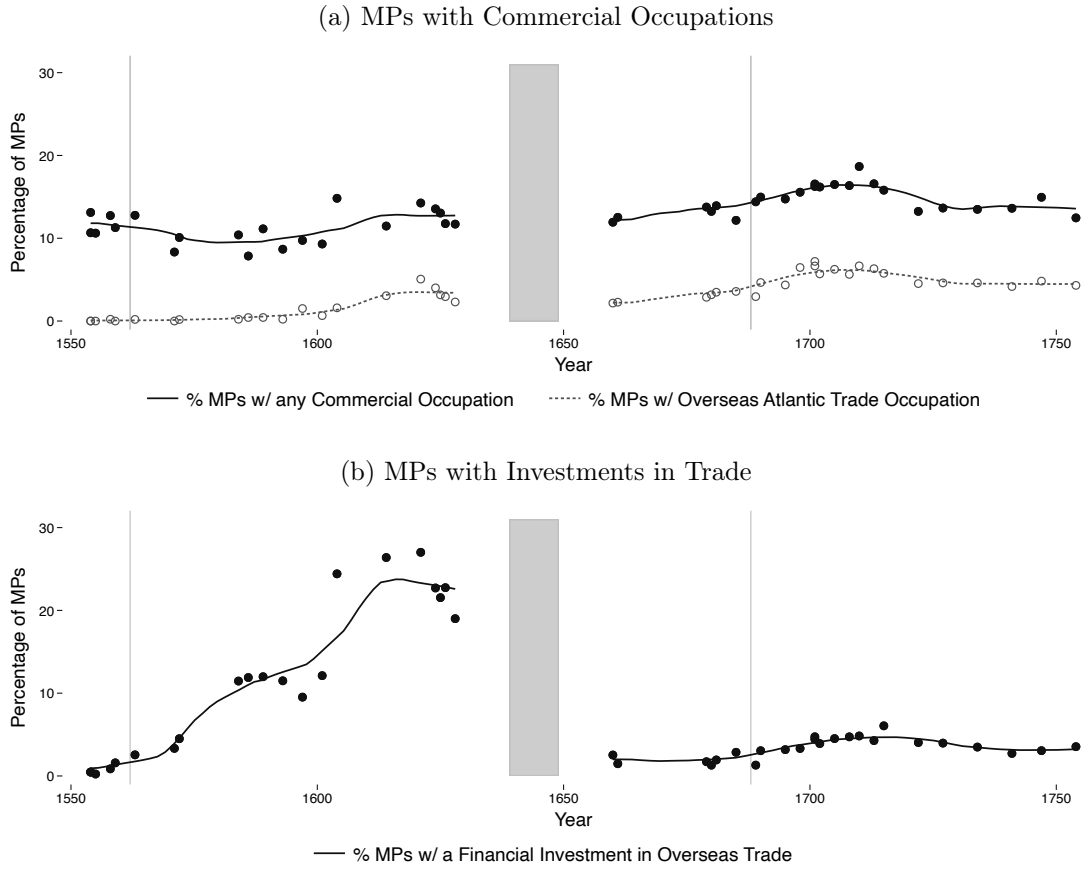
First, I consider the economic interest dimension of the typology, asking how the economic interests of MPs changed as Atlantic trade expanded. Figure 2 presents these trends. Figure 2 shows overall trends in the representation of commercial interests in Parliament from 1550 to 1750. The top panel (a) shows the percentage of MPs who had commercial occupations. This is broken out into the percentage of MPs who held *any* commercial occupation—whether related to any overseas trade (including traditional continental trade), domestic wholesale trade, and domestic retail—along with the percentage of MPs who were specifically occupied in overseas trade in the Atlantic economy (either eastward to Asia or westward to the Americas).

I find that the representation of MPs with commercial occupations changed very little over the long 17th century. In the pre-English Civil War period, the percentage of MPs occupied in commerce moved up and down slightly but never fell below 7.9% or rose above 14.8%. The largest, albeit still moderate, increase occurred in the post-1640 period. In the early 18th century, the share of MPs with commercial occupations peaked at 18.7%. Overall, the increase in MPs with commercial occupations can, at best, be said to have increased very gradually.

Amongst those occupied in commerce, the percentage of MPs with occupations related to overseas trade in the Atlantic economy grew modestly but consistently—rising from no representatives in the early pre-1640 period to an eventual high of 7.2%.³⁸ As significant

³⁸The overseas Atlantic trader represented in the earliest period even before the sailing of the first British-flagged slave ship was Robert Elyot (Bristol, 1542) a Broad Street merchant who participated in a

Figure 2: Trends in Commercial Representation in Parliament, 1550-1750



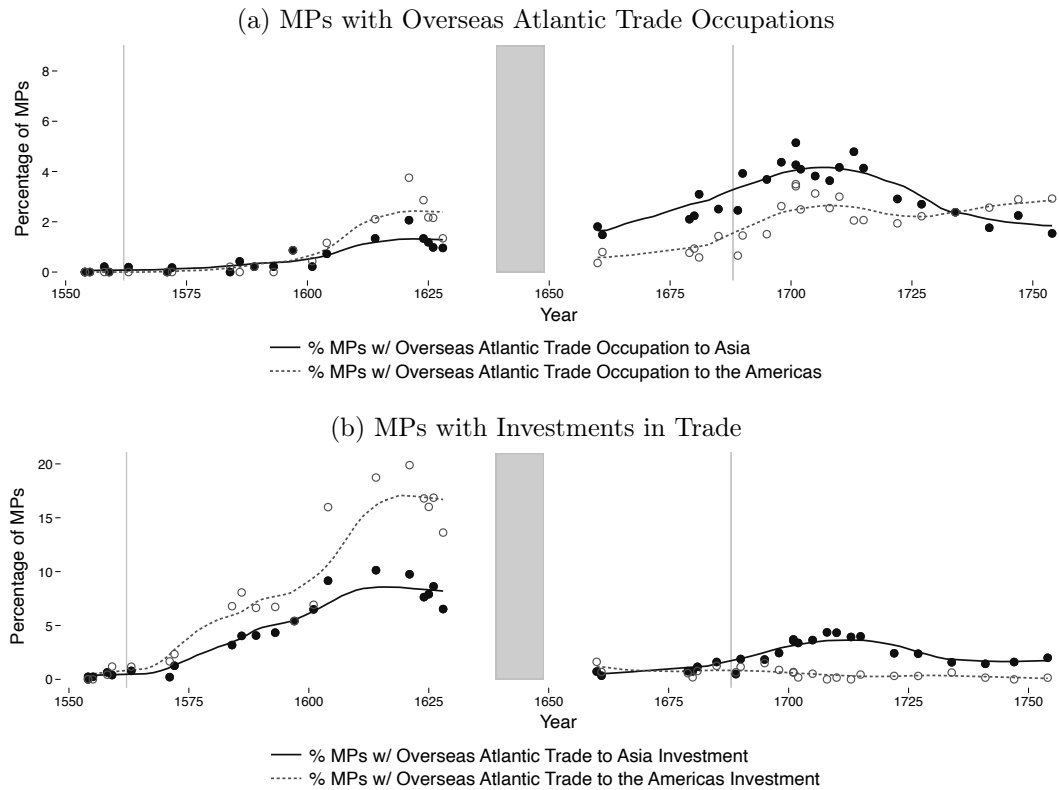
Notes: The plot presents trends in the commercial interests of MPs. The top plot shows the percentage of MPs with *any* commercial occupation—including both overseas trading, wholesale, and domestic retail occupations—via the solid line and the share of MPs with commercial occupations in Atlantic overseas trade (either eastward or westward) via the dashed line. The bottom plot shows trends in the percentage of MPs with financial investments in overseas trade. The plotted categories are not mutually exclusive within or across plots. The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and gray vertical lines indicate the first sailing of a British-flagged slave ship (1562) and the Glorious Revolution settlement (1688).

as the growth was, however, the magnitude of representation is perhaps more notable—at no point over this two-hundred-year period did Atlantic traders make up as much as 10% of parliamentary representatives.

The lower panel (b) of Figure 2 presents the trend in the percentage of MPs with financial investments in overseas trading companies. While the share of MPs with commercial occupations changed relatively little over the period, the share of MPs with financial investments in trade increased from effectively zero to well over 25% between 1550 and the English Civil War before falling back to single digits after the Restoration.

Figure 3 considers these patterns by the geographic sphere of overseas Atlantic trade. The representation of occupied merchants in the Atlantic economy (plot a) was comparable in voyage to Newfoundland in the 1520s.

Figure 3: Trends in the overseas trade interests of MPs by the geography of trade, 1550-1750



Notes: The plots present trends in the percentage of MPs who have (a) occupations in overseas trade in the Atlantic economy or (b) investments in overseas trade in the Atlantic economy plotted separately for each geographic sphere of trade. Note that the y-axes differ by plot to aid in visualizing the trends. The plotted categories are not mutually exclusive within or across plots. The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and gray vertical lines indicate the first sailing of a British-flagged slave ship (1562) and the Glorious Revolution settlement (1688).

levels and trends across both eastward and westward trades prior to 1640. At most, these traders accounted for just a few percent of MPs. (As I demonstrate in Appendix E, generic merchants—those not directly occupied in either of the two spheres of expanding Atlantic trade—accounted for the majority of commercial MPs, even into the early 18th century.)

After the Restoration, the trends diverged somewhat. MPs occupied in trade to Asia continued to grow—peaking at 5.1% of seats in parliament in the early 1700s. At the same time, the growth of merchants occupied in trading to the Americas failed to keep pace—at no point did westward traders account for more than 3.5% of sitting MPs after the Restoration. Thus, despite the enormous growth in the Atlantic economy, those individuals directly involved in new Atlantic trades constituted a small percentage of all MPs. They constituted the most in the decades immediately after the Glorious Revolution had

reorganized Crown-Parliament relations.

In contrast to MPs occupied in overseas Atlantic trade, the growth of MPs with investments in trade (plot b) exhibited strong geographic and temporal patterns consistent with the organization of the trades over time. In both geographic spheres, investors in the new Atlantic economy grew dramatically prior to the Civil War—peaking at around 10% of Parliament for Asia trades and 20% for American trades—as much as five times the representation of those directly occupied in these trades.

After the Restoration, however, the share of MPs with investments in trade dwindled markedly. In trade with Asia, the share of occupied MPs and investor MPs exhibited similar levels and trends. Indeed, throughout the post-Restoration period, the overlap between these two groups was high—for instance, more than 70% of investors in the Asia trade were also active members of that trade.³⁹

As I demonstrate in Appendix E, it was not the case that the *entré* of commercial wealth into parliament occurred via the *sons* of merchants. Second-generation commercial wealth accounted for less than 5% of MPs and did not grow dramatically over the period.

The Parliamentary Representation of Trade in Societal Context

How do the trends in the parliamentary representation of trade track the distribution of merchants and their wealth in society writ large? Given the limited availability of evidence on the societal distribution of occupations and wealth from the 17th century, this contextualization is quite difficult.

However, I am able to draw on Grassby (1995) and Lindert and Williamson (1982) to provide a rough approximation of the pre-1640 and post-1660 economic landscape (see also Appendix I). Grassby (1995) estimates that before 1640, there were approximately 3,000 “businessmen” with wealth over £500, and a further 800 “substantial businessmen” with wealth over £1,000.⁴⁰ Grassby contends that there was limited growth in this business

³⁹39% of those actively occupied were also classed as investors.

⁴⁰These businessmen encompassed all manner of business occupations. Overseas traders were some smaller but difficult-to-estimate fraction. More difficult still would be to identify overseas traders involved in Asia and Americas trade as opposed to pre-existing continental trade.

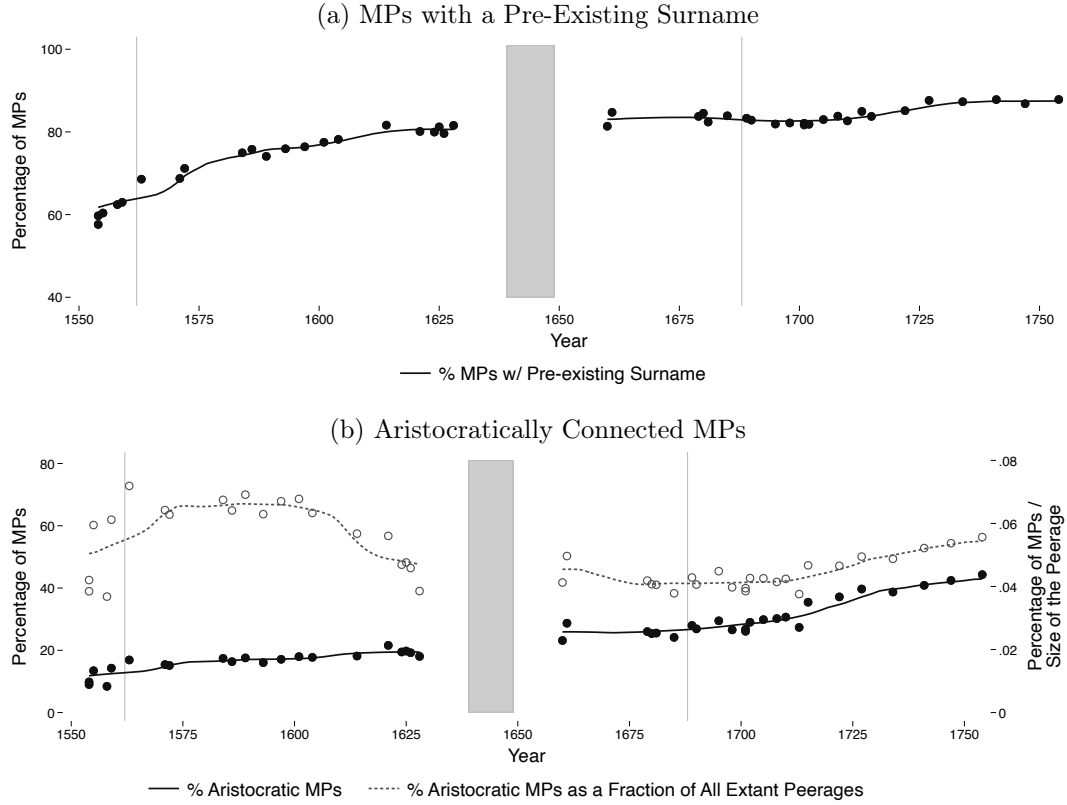
interest from the beginning to the end of the century—he estimates that substantial businessmen grew from 800 to 1,000 between approx. 1600 and 1700. In those parliaments in which commercial interests were most represented, I calculate that MPs occupied in commerce constituted on the order of 13-16% of Grassby’s extant “substantial businessmen.”⁴¹ Thus, this business elite of early modern England was well (descriptively) represented in Parliament.

As an alternative to Grassby, I also draw on Lindert and Williamson (1982)’s occupational and wealth estimates from the end of the 17th century. Using the alternative conceptualization of “merchant” (as opposed to “businessmen”), they estimate that there were approximately 130,000 occupied “merchants” in England, 8,000 of whom had family income over £200, and 2,000 who had family income above £400. By comparison, in the same period, those with “high titles and skills”—in effect, the non-mercantile elite encompassing Lords, rentiers, esquires, gentlemen, and so forth—numbered about 63,000, or half the number of merchants. By this accounting—which allows a relative comparison of the societal versus political distribution of merchants *and* high-titled individuals—I find that merchant MPs constituted approximately 0.1% of all English merchants in the late 17th century, while high-status MPs constituted approximately 0.5% of all high-titled individuals.⁴² Although these estimates are rough, they suggest that the mercantile interest was significantly less represented in parliament, given its distribution in society, compared to traditional societal elites.

⁴¹I calculate approximately 700 unique commercial MPs who served before 1640 and 900 unique commercial MPs who served in the period 1660-1750. I calculate that, at most, 131 MPs were occupied in commerce in any one parliament during the period.

⁴²To calculate these percentages, I divide the maximum number of merchant MPs in a parliament—131—by Lindert and Williamson’s estimate of 130,000 total merchants in England. I estimate the share of MPs who are high status—i.e., rentiers, esquires, gentry, etc.—as the residual MPs after removing commercial MPs, other capitalists (i.e., producers), and farmers. This results in approximately 360 high-status MPs, depending on the specific Parliament. I divide this figure by 72,000 (the 63,000 high titles and skills individuals + 9,000 military officers who also had high status in the period and often sought parliamentary seats).

Figure 4: Trends in social and family backgrounds of MPs, 1550-1750



Notes: The plots present trends in MPs: (a) who share the surname of a previous MP who served their nation (England or Wales), and (b) with a family connection to a member of the hereditary aristocracy. The y-axis of the plots is different. Plot (b) has a second y-axis that normalizes the aristocratic trend by the size of the aristocracy. The plotted categories are not mutually exclusive across plots. The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and gray vertical lines indicate the first sailing of a British-flagged slave ship (1562) and the Glorious Revolution settlement (1688). Appendix E shows the surname plots for England and Wales separately. Appendix H presents trends in the size of the peerage.

The Socio-Familial Backgrounds of MPs

How did the dynamism in the socio-familial dimension of persistence compare with that of overseas Atlantic trading interests? Figure 4 presents the trends in socio-familial representation in terms of both pre-existing (i.e., common-to-politics) surnames (plot a) and MPs with family connections to the hereditary aristocracy (plot b). The plots reveal little evidence that expanding trade over the period drove a general opening of political power to new social groups. To the contrary, the top panel demonstrates that the share of MPs with pre-existing surnames rose over the period—from around 60% of MPs to around 85% by the mid-1700s.

Similarly, the lower panel demonstrates that the share of MPs with aristocratic connections grew as well—from around 15% in the late 1500s to 40% by the end of the period.⁴³ As

⁴³In the case of the late 16th century, Haslert (2004) corroborates the general finding that aristocratically-

a share of all peerages, the percentage of aristocratically-connected MPs fluctuated more as the size of the peerage grew in the early 17th century (see Appendix H). Insofar as some MPs during this period had connections to a newly created peer, this aristocratic parliamentary elite may have been transforming via societal transformation.⁴⁴

Elite persistence, measured in terms of MPs with pre-existing surnames and MPs with aristocratic connections, remained extremely stable over the period. If anything, these trends demonstrate the increasing concentration of political power within traditional elite groups in society despite significant changes in the economy. Therefore, as the Atlantic economy grew, there is no evidence that political power (descriptively) opened itself to new social groups.

5 The Socio-Familial Backgrounds of MPs with an Interest in Trade

The previous results indicate that the rise of overseas trade resulted in a modest increase in the number of MPs with occupations related to trade and a more substantial—though not permanent—increase in the share of MPs holding investments in Atlantic trading companies. Despite these changes, however, there is no evidence that the rise of overseas trade fundamentally changed the social and family backgrounds of those who held political power.

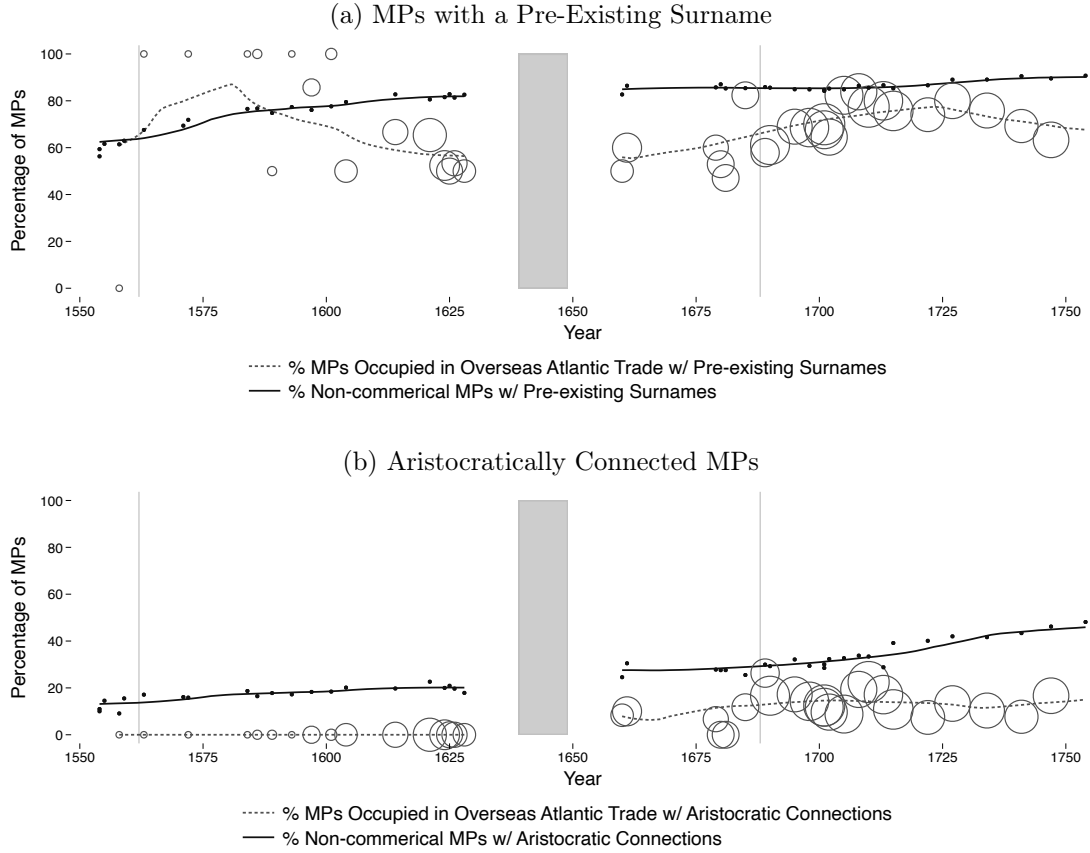
However, these results cannot speak to whether the representation of Atlantic trade *itself* came from new social and family groups. In this section, I examine the social backgrounds of the MPs with an interest in overseas Atlantic trade to understand the extent to which this specific group was, or was not, drawn from existing social and familial political elites.

To do so, I present the graphical evidence of the descriptive trends, focusing on both MPs with overseas trade-related occupations and MPs invested in overseas trade, both in the

connected MPs made up a relatively modest share of parliamentary representatives, a fact that might otherwise strike readers as surprising.

⁴⁴Identifying the exact peerage creation date and family member of the MP who held that peerage would be an avenue for further research.

Figure 5: Difference in socio-familial backgrounds of MPs occupied in overseas Atlantic trade versus non-commercial MPs



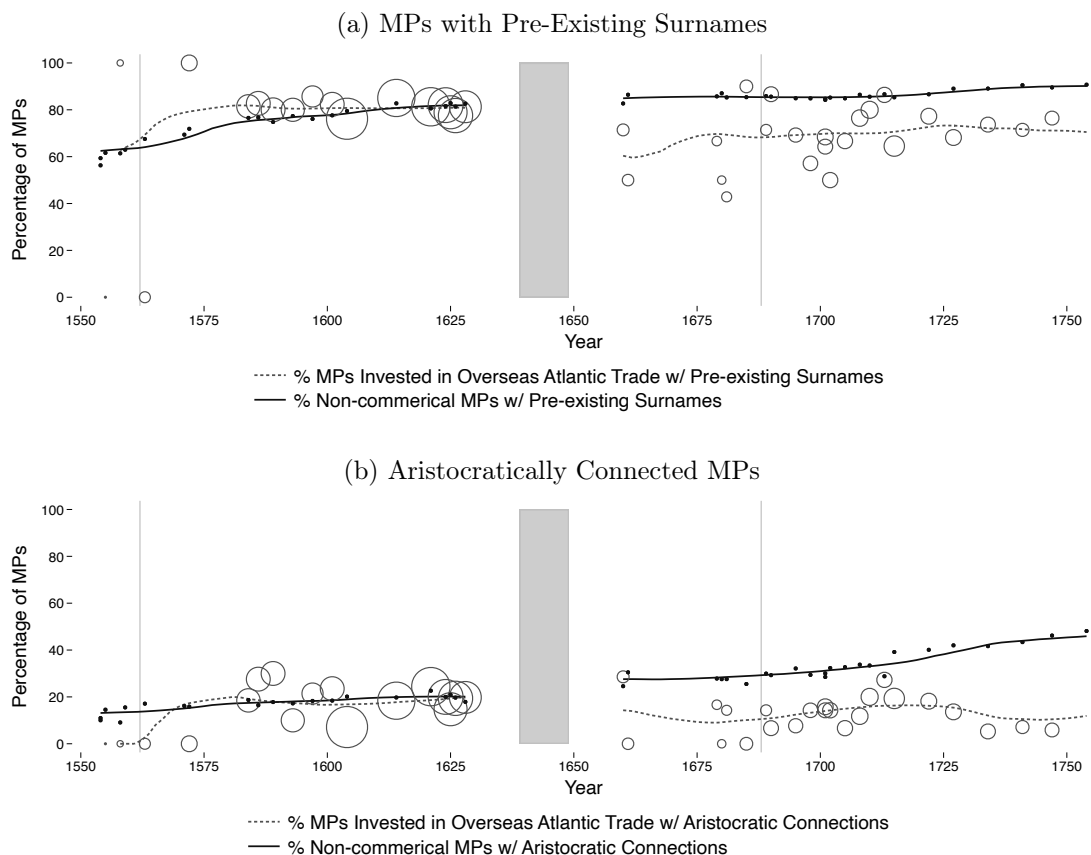
Notes: The plots show the share of MPs with overseas Atlantic trade interests who share a surname with a pre-existing MP (plot a) or who have a family connection to the hereditary aristocracy (plot b). The same trends are plotted for non-commercial MPs (solid black line) for comparative context. The size of the hollow circles for MPs with trade interests is proportional to the number of trade-interested MPs in a given parliament. The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and gray vertical lines indicate the first sailing of a British-flagged slave ship (1562) and the Glorious Revolution settlement (1688).

Asia trade and Americas trade.⁴⁵ Figure 5 presents the share of MPs with occupations in overseas Atlantic trade with a given socio-familial background (i.e., pre-existing surname (a) or aristocratically connected (b)). The trend is presented with a dashed line, and the share of all MPs involved in overseas Atlantic trade is represented by the size of the hollow circles located at each parliament. In order to provide a comparative context for these trends, the plots also include the share of *non-commercial* MPs with the same social or family background.⁴⁶

⁴⁵See also Appendix F.

⁴⁶I don't scale the solid points by the share of non-commercial MPs in parliament as (a) this would clutter the plot and (b) be unnecessary since the scale would be proportional to the share of overseas Atlantic traders in parliament (though note that this would not be exactly proportional since non-overseas non-Atlantic trading MPs are not included in the plot).

Figure 6: Difference in socio-familial backgrounds of MPs invested in trade versus non-commercial MPs



Notes: The plots show the share of MPs with investments in overseas Atlantic trade who share a surname with a pre-existing MP (plot a) or who have a family connection to the hereditary aristocracy (plot b). The same trends are plotted for non-commercial MPs (solid black line) for comparative context. The size of the hollow circles for MPs with trade interests is proportional to the number of trade-interested MPs in a given parliament. The size of the hollow circles for MPs with trade interests is proportional to the number of trade-interested MPs in a given parliament. The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and gray vertical lines indicate the first sailing of a British-flagged slave ship (1562) and the Glorious Revolution settlement (1688).

I find that in the earliest years of the Atlantic economy, those few MPs involved in overseas Atlantic trade were more likely to be from traditional elite groups in politics and society than the average non-commercial MP in parliament. This is especially true in the context of common-to-politics surnames. But as the 17th century progressed, this distribution was reversed—MPs occupied in overseas Atlantic trade were less likely to share a surname that previously existed in parliament. Even in the early 18th century, at the height of post-Restoration mercantile representation (recall Figure 2), MPs occupied in overseas Atlantic trade were still slightly less likely to share a pre-existing political surname. Though the relative difference is significant, it's still important to recognize that in level terms, more than half of MPs occupied in overseas trade shared a surname with an MP from a previous

parliament throughout the period.

The aristocratic backgrounds of overseas Atlantic trading MPs display starker patterns. With the exception of the earliest few traders in the mid-16th century, those MPs occupied in overseas Atlantic trade uniformly lacked connections to the hereditary aristocracy prior to the Interregnum. After the Restoration, the aristocratic connections amongst these trading MPs grew, but were approximately half that non-commercial MPs through most of the period. At most during the long 17th century, 25% of MPs occupied in overseas Atlantic trade had a family connection to the hereditary aristocracy. While for non-commercial MPs, this share peaked at double that—nearly half of the group. Thus, occupied trader MPs relatively quickly became relatively more diverse in their socio-familial backgrounds. Their marked lack of aristocratic connections suggests that these MPs were, in fact, being drawn from outside the narrowest apex of traditional society. At the same time, surname connections to former MPs indicate that they were not true “political outsiders” either.

By contrast, investors in overseas Atlantic trade were initially indistinguishable from non-commercial MPs in their socio-familial backgrounds (Figure 6). The growing overseas investment opportunities were taken up by MPs with very traditional backgrounds (relative to their non-commercial parliamentary peers). Around 80% of pre-Civil War MP investors in overseas Atlantic trade shared a surname with a pre-existing MP (plot a); and around 15-20% of these MPs had a family connection to the hereditary aristocracy (plot b).

After the Restoration, the trends in investor backgrounds diverged from those of non-commercial MPs more generally. In the case of pre-existing surnames and aristocratic connections, non-commercial MPs maintained or became more concentrated in their connections to traditional social groups. As the heyday of overseas investment waned after the Restoration, the backgrounds of investors in overseas trading companies became slightly more diverse—approximately 60% shared a surname with a former MP (as compared to 80% in the pre-Civil War period); and, on average, 10% had a family connection to the hereditary aristocracy (as compared to, effectively none, in the pre-period). Thus, a gradual opening of investment to new socio-familial groups occurred as major opportunities for

investment declined.

Appendix F presents these same trends by the geographic sphere of trade, in the interest of space.

6 Interpreting the Trends in Elite Persistence and Turnover

In this section, I offer an interpretation the trends in two hundred years of elite persistence presented in the previous sections, as well as a characterization of those trends in light of the paper’s analytic typology. I begin by summarizing several patterns that emerge from the analysis.

First, on the socio-familial dimension of persistence, the story is relatively simple: the rise of overseas Atlantic trade had little to no effect on the ability of pre-existing political families and aristocrats to maintain their hold on political power during this period. Economic change did not constitute a significant break in the traditional sources of socio-familial power in early modern England. This finding corroborates work that documents the persistence of social elites—specifically, Oxbridge students—in parliament through significant economic and political changes over the centuries (Clark, 2014, 103-5).⁴⁷

Second, however, on the economic dimension the story is more nuanced. While the rise of overseas Atlantic trade did coincide with the parliamentary entrée of some individuals directly occupied in this trade, *overall* levels of commercial MPs—be they overseas merchants or domestic business owners—were, in fact, relatively stable during the long 17th century. Moreover, while the number of MPs with occupations tied to overseas Atlantic trade increased during this period, at no point did such traders constitute the majority of MPs with commercial occupations. There is no evidence, therefore, that the significant economic transformations wrought by Atlantic trade—the doubling of London imports, the ten-fold growth in trade-derived output—resulted in a significant rise in the number of MPs actively participating in trade. made their political impact through the numerical parliamentary presence of those who actively participated in the trade. Nor is there evi-

⁴⁷Though Clark’s results for the pre-19th century period are asserted rather than demonstrated.

dence that it was the second generation *sons* of merchants who represented the political relevance of commerce.

Third, while the share of MPs with overseas Atlantic trade occupations rose—though modestly so—this increase was much larger for MPs with occupations related to the eastward trade to Asia following the Restoration. Thus, as trade to the Americas was de-regulated, representation amongst those directly occupied declined. The opening of American colonial trade to all English-flagged ships sealed the coffin of those companies that had not yet succumbed to economic incompatibilities between colonial trade and monopoly organization. For example, the Virginia and Newfoundland Companies had already collapsed by 1624 even before Parliament took an anti-oligarchy stance.⁴⁸

By contrast, the main company of the eastward trade to Asia, the E.I.C., overcame serious threats to its monopoly during the Interregnum and remained protected from competition into the 18th century (Keay, 1991).⁴⁹ One interpretation of the differing representation between Asia and Americas traders post-1660 is that it reflected the changing relative importance of parliamentary officeholding given the divergent regulatory situations of each sphere of trade. Eastward traders to Asia may have perceived that parliamentary power was still required in order to protect their monopoly, while westward traders to the Americas did not. Another—possibly complimentary interpretation—is consistent with historical accounts of the differing economic organizations of trade. The relative risk and importance of new modes of production may have seen westward traders more likely to invest in political influence within colonial government and to spend their time abroad, becoming a distinctly *American* mercantile elite.

Fourth, the share of MPs with investments in trade exploded in the run-up to the English Civil War, then fell precipitously following the Restoration. This mirrors the growth

⁴⁸The only truly *new* monopoly of consequence to emerge in the post-Restoration period was the South Sea Company. Although organized under the auspices of supplying slaves to South America, the company was largely a vehicle of state finance that collapsed in an infamous speculative bubble (Dickson, 2016).

⁴⁹Other eastward trading monopolies dissolved or were *de facto* opened. For instance, while the Eastland Company's charter was reaffirmed in 1661, in 1672, Parliament effectively opened the trade to other nations and those able to pay a fee. Nevertheless, the company still supported 400 traders through the period (Grassby, 1995).

in investment opportunities, suggesting that MPs were willing and able to diversify their economic interests when opportunities presented themselves. These investors followed the same relative patterns of occupied traders with respect to the Interregnum—prior to the Civil War, investors in the American trades dominated, while after the Restoration, remaining investors were those invested in the E.I.C. Insofar as the Civil War and Interregnum produced this open American trade (Brenner, 2003), one can say that the investments that tipped political preferences towards war during the Long Parliament (Jha, 2015), were also those that *undid* most of the overseas investment system by the end of the 17th century. Thus, the lack of later investment was likely endogenous to the investment that did occur prior to 1640.

The dissolution of investment opportunities in the westward trades after the Restoration certainly explains the precipitous decline in indirect participants in the trade. Though, as noted above, I do *not* find that the decline in indirect participation via investments was offset by an increase in the representation of active merchants in this trade. Thus, the results do not strongly suggest *substitutability* between active involvement and indirect investment.

Lastly, when looking at the intersection of the economic and socio-familial domains of persistence, it seems clear that while some commercial MPs and MPs with investments in trade constituted new entrants to power, the extent of new entry—even among this select population—was relatively limited. Thus, taken together, the long 17th century is characterized by a significant degree of persistence. Most MPs during the period demonstrated *full persistence*, perpetuating the same non-commercial economic interests, having been drawn from an existing political class. Amongst those MPs that *did* exhibit turnover on the economic interest dimension, their occupation in the Atlantic economy was not associated with a substantial degree of socio-familial turnover. Thus, to the extent that Parliament experienced turnover in economic elites, this was largely the result of *captured economic turnover*. This characterization of *captured economic turnover* was further true of the extent to which MPs represented the Atlantic economy by virtue of their investments in trading ventures. The entry of new economic interests did not come at the expense of

established political families or the hereditary aristocracy as the Atlantic economy grew.

7 Conclusion

The consequences of economic change for the distribution of political power stand at the heart of the study of political economy. Because political institutions have distributional consequences (Knight, 1992), and allow those in power to exercise discretion in decision-making in line with their preferences, *who* occupies positions of political power—not merely changes in institutional structures—matters for distributional outcomes (Besley, 2005). Consequently, it matters whether, and to what extent transformations like economic change re-make the political elite.

In this paper, I study how changes in *de facto* economic power are reflected in positions of representative, *de jure* political power. A comprehensive accounting of the degree of elite persistence (or turnover) in the context of economic change depends not only on characterizing changes in the occupations and economic interests of elites but also on describing the relationship that “new” elites may have to incumbent political families and social groups. In this paper, I present a simple typology of elite persistence along these two dimensions and use it to guide a detailed empirical analysis of the dynamics of elite persistence in response to the expansion of overseas trade during England’s storied, long 17th century.

Empirically, I draw on the historical scholarship and newly-collected MP biographical data over two centuries to argue that economic changes that constituted the growing Atlantic economy broadly favored the incumbent political elite. Despite the radical transformation of England’s overseas trade, the political elite, generally, displayed significant persistence. The representation of expanding trade found its parliamentary embodiment most clearly in those members of the incumbent elite who *invested* in the new economy rather than those who were actively occupied in it. Overseas Atlantic trade obtained modest representation, but that representation did not constitute a major upheaval in the *de jure* distribution of power.

The long 17th century is a storied period in British political and economic history. As noted in the paper’s introduction, one of the classic lines of argumentation is that the economic changes of the Atlantic economy re-made political and economic power during this period, culminating in institutional changes and representative control that set England on a rapid path toward political stability and economic prosperity (North and Weingast, 1989; Stasavage, 2002; Acemoglu, Johnson and Robinson, 2005; Cox, 2016). This paper alone does not definitively answer the question of “what, precisely, changed and why” during this century of transformation—indeed, the paper’s empirical evidence is about *de jure* representation, not a comprehensive accounting of the societal distribution of power, an important, albeit difficult, avenue for future research. But it does contribute an important piece of the historical puzzle—I document that some shifts in the political equilibrium did precede national institutional change (Pincus and Robinson, 2014; Jha, 2015), rather than deriving primarily therefrom. But the role of trade in parliamentary representation was fundamentally circumscribed and generally reflected the economic transformation of an existing socio-political elite rather than the wholesale rise of a *nouveau riche*. To the extent merchant wealth generated England’s modern economic development (Acemoglu, Johnson and Robinson, 2005), this paper suggests that it was never the result of the numerical descriptive representation of Atlantic trading elite.

Still, there are only so many things that one paper can accomplish, leaving a number of avenues for further research, even in the descriptive realm. First, it is the case that the socio-familial categories that I offer are contextually important, but broad. Further work could disaggregate precisely which types of families, aristocrats, and social groups more broadly were most likely to persist in power. This in turn could suggest what attributes and/or resources allow some families to insulate themselves from change, or alternatively to transform their economic activities to participate in new economic sectors. The paper operates from the assumption that *de jure* power and embodied representation are meaningful in this historical context, and motivates why that should be the case. However, this assumption could be relaxed in future work to understand the extent to which different embodied interests coordinated to produce political outcomes, or how those outcomes may

have been pursued outside of parliamentary representation (e.g., connections at court).

In addition to improving our understanding of an archetypal case in the political economy literature, the distinct consequences of these different expansions of trade offer important insights into when and where we may expect to see economic transformations result in political disruption more generally. These descriptive patterns presented here are not a causally identified test of a particular theory of *why* elites persist; however, I believe them to be an important basis for causal theory-building that aims to understand the conditions under which we should expect economic change to alternately disrupt, or preserve an existing political elite (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2006*a,b*). As described in the paper’s introduction, to date, existing theory and empirical evidence offer competing, or at the very least, imprecise predictions, and therefore explanations, for persistence and turnover.

One interpretation of this paper’s results is that they suggest an important causal role for particular *features* of innovations and the economic changes that derive therefrom (Frieden and Silve, 2023). The complementarity of innovations to existing elite assets could be expected to increase the likelihood that elites are able to capture the benefits of those economic changes and persist in power—i.e., generating *captured economic turnover*. Moreover, the patterns evident in England’s long 17th century suggest that when economic change is more centralized and easily regulated—as was the case with much of England’s overseas trade—the existing political elite are more likely to capture the benefits for themselves. Finally, the extent to which innovations are exogenously developed and can be deployed by rival states—as trade-related technologies like navigation and ship-building were during a 17th century fraught with inter-state rivalries and existential threat—may deeply condition how forcefully elites promote change, even changes that are not necessarily complimentary to their own resources. Future work can and should more explicitly theorize these individual and contextual aspects of elite persistence and turnover in the service of a rich, mechanistic explanation for persistence.

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Online Appendix to “Elite Persistence in the Era of England’s Expanding Overseas Trade”

Appendix is for online publication only.

Date: June 3, 2025

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A Trends in Commercial Activity

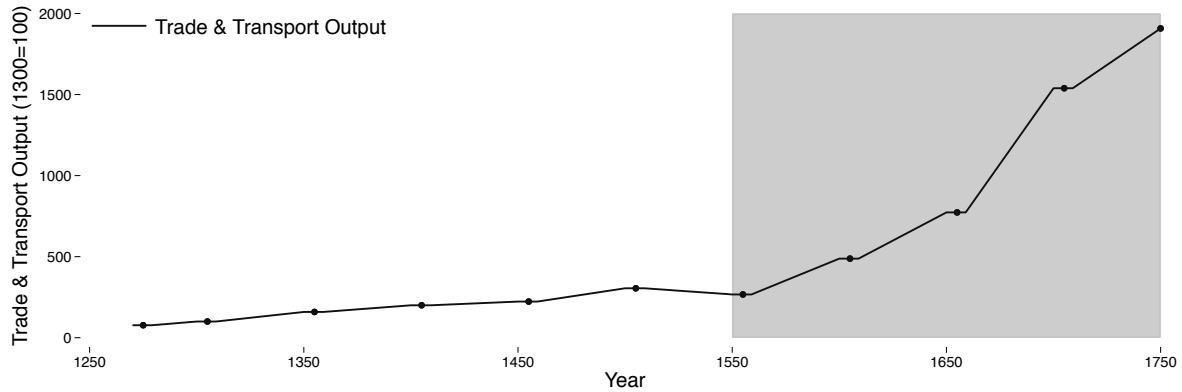
This appendix presents additional figures that document trends in commercial activity during the 16th, 17th and early 18th centuries.

Figures A1 and A2 present two alternative ways of visualizing the growth in trade during the 16th and 17th century in England. The period of study of this paper is shaded in gray for both. Figure A1 presents the trend in the combined contribution of trade and transport to national output in England (with the year 1300 normalized to 100). From 1550 onwards, there was substantial growth in the extent to which trade and transportation mattered for national production in England. This coincides with the growth of trade to the Americas and to Africa and Asia.

Figure A2 breaks out the growth into the components of each international and domestic trade. What the series indicate is that both international trade and domestic trade increased. So, as goods increasingly moved between England and other nations, so too was there an attendant increase in goods moving within England. This reflects the domestic economic effects of expanding trade—the movement of imports through the country, and the movement of exports from centers of production to ports to the global marketplace.

Figure A4 presents the trends in the number of East India Company voyages (and tonnage of those voyages) sailing annually from 1600-1750.

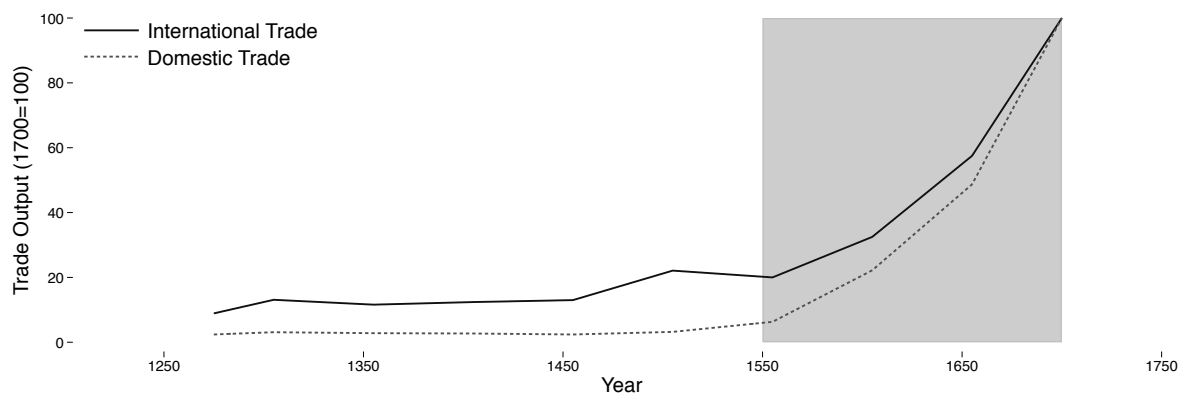
Figure A1: Trends in economic output deriving from trade and transport, 1270-1750



Sources: Broadberry et al. (2015), pg. 181.

Notes: The above plot shows trends in the combined contribution of the trade and transport sectors to national output in England. The data is given as averages for specific decades (indicated by the scatter) by Broadberry et al. (2015). The gray shaded period corresponds to the period studied in this paper. Output figures are given relative to the base year 1300 (1300=100).

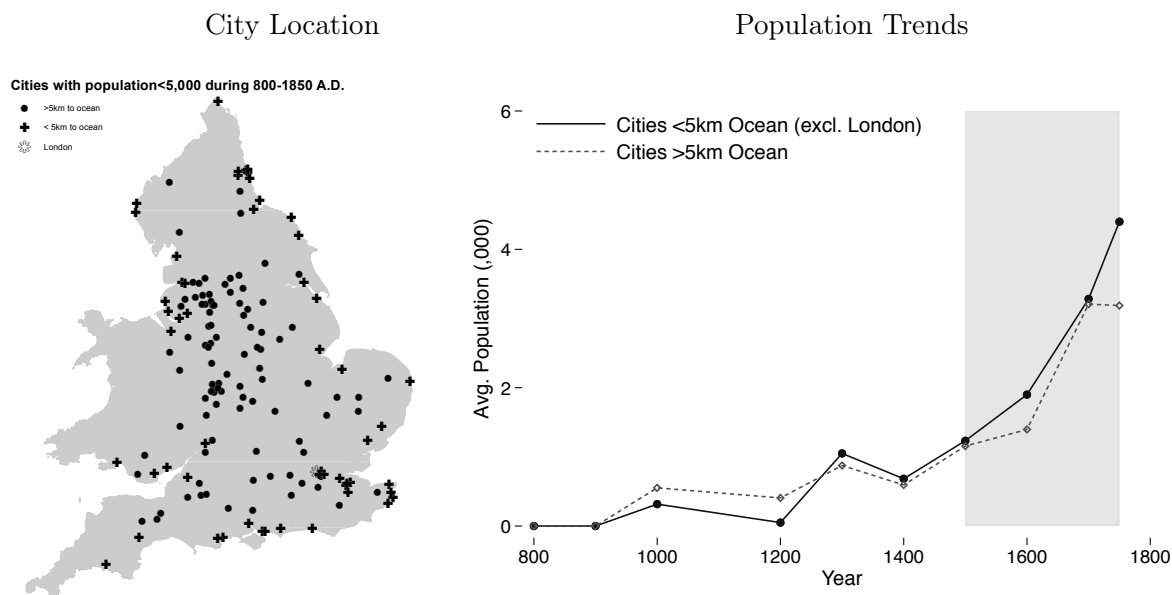
Figure A2: Trends in economic output deriving domestic and international trade, 1270-1700



Sources: Broadberry et al. (2015), pg. 170.

Notes: The above plot shows trends in the contribution of each domestic and international trade to output. The data is given as averages for specific decades (indicated by the scatter) by the source. The gray shaded period corresponds to the period studied in this paper. Output figures are given relative to the base year 1700 (1700=100).

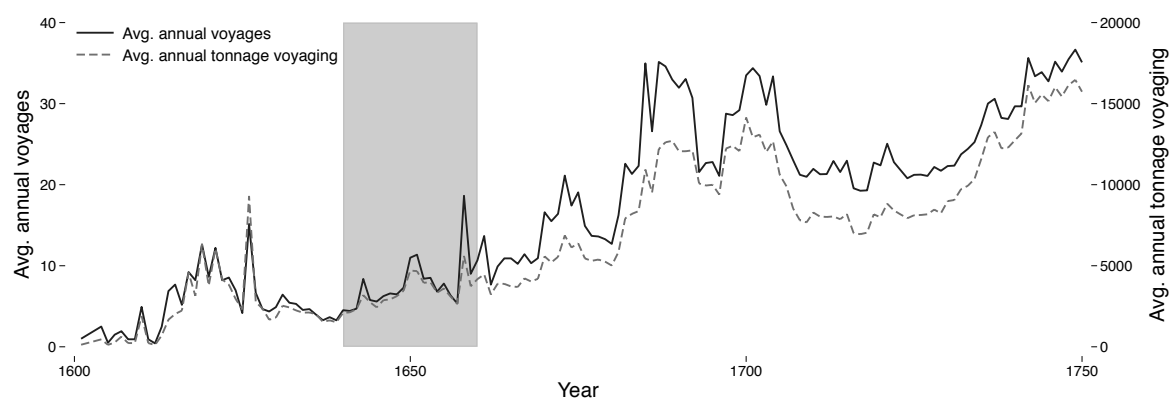
Figure A3: Location and population trends of cities that achieved 5,000 people during 850-1850



Sources: Cities data is from Bairoch, Batou and Chevre (1988).

Notes: The map above left indicates the location of cities in England that obtained a population of at least 5,000 people at some point prior to 1850. The crosses indicate the subset of those cities within 5km of the ocean, while the remainder are represented by points. The plot above right shows trends in average population for those same cities, excluding London, which was so populous that it dwarfs all other cities. The gray shaded period indicates the (approximate) period of study for this paper.

Figure A4: Trends in East India Company Voyages and Tonnage



Sources: Sutton (1981), pg. 162.

Notes: This figure presents trends in average annual voyages as well as the average annual tonnage voyaging of the English East India Company from 1600 to 1750. Sutton lists the years that ships were in service, the number of voyages taken during that period, and the estimated tonnage of the ship. Sutton does not list the dates of individual voyages. I construct annual measures by averaging the number of voyages (and the total tonnage voyages) over the years of service. The lifetime of a ship was not long, which means that in most cases these averages are done over only a few years. In the longest cases, they are averaged over a few decades (but this is rare). The first recorded ships in the Sutton data are from 1600.

B The Value of Parliamentary Representation

In this appendix, I briefly describe how MPs obtained their seats and the nature and value of parliamentary representation.

To understand persistence and turnover in Parliament requires an understanding of what Parliament could do, and thus why MPs sought their seats. Parliament's primary functions throughout the period were defined in relation to the other center of national political power—the Crown. Parliament's primary powers involved granting “supply” (direct taxes, like those over land) to the Crown, and initiating (public and private-specific) legislation, which might bear on domestic or international commerce (Sgroi, 2010).¹

Prior to 1688, the Crown on the other hand, reserved significant powers. Crown approval was required for acts passed by Parliament; the Crown controlled important levers of taxation, notably customs revenues; and the Crown controlled *how* it spent Parliamentary supply (Cox, 2016). In particular, royal investments in the navy and war-making decisions bore heavily on trade. The Crown also administered justice related to trade through the Admiralty courts (Steckley, 1978). And crucially, through the Royal Prerogative, the Crown initially controlled monopoly rights in trade. Though the Prerogative was heavily contested by Parliament throughout the period (Ekelund and Tollison, 1981; Brenner, 2003).

Obtaining a seat in Parliament required wealth and social status. Candidates sought a seat from one of approximately 250 constituencies—the generally rural counties, and the disparate set of “urban” boroughs. Those who were selected owed their seats to a highly restricted electorate—typically the wealthy landed gentry and a handful of merchants—which they helped to cultivate through their own expenditures (Plumb, 1969).²

A Parliamentary seat was valuable both because it confirmed the social standing of an MP—a not insignificant prize—and because of the instrumental benefit in terms of both private and public policy described above (Kishlansky, 1986; Thrush, 2010*a*). The modern notion of *representation* by an MP existed, but this was not the universal way in which MPs roles were considered.³ And thus the interests that MPs themselves embodied by virtue of their economic activities mattered a lot for their behavior in Parliament (Jha, 2015).

¹The denial of supply to James I and Charles I were critical decisions for which the value of a Parliamentary seat was essential. To illustrate that, Charles I appointed a number of his opponents as county sheriffs in preparation for the 1626 Parliament to preclude them from serving as MPs, two posts that they could not concurrently hold.

²Only towards the end of the 17th century did party organizations develop in what was, until then, a candidate-centered electoral environment.

³While sometimes MPs were left to exercise initiative as they saw fit, at other times “they would be given detailed instructions and perhaps also ancillary paperwork to help them frame their arguments, draft any required legislation or provide evidence in case of inquiry” (Thrush, 2010*b*). The historiography notes occasional, but not universal, instances of accountability: “Many Members feared heavy criticism from their constituents if they failed to protect the latter’s interests.” (Thrush, 2010*b*).

C Coding the Economic Interests of MPs

One of the contributions of this paper is a new dataset that traces the economic interests of Members of Parliament from across the period of study. This dataset is derived from narrative text biographies originally published in printed volumes published by the The History of Parliament Project (HPP). The specific volumes are *The House of Commons 1509-1558*, *The House of Commons 1558-1603*, *The House of Commons 1604-1629*, *The House of Commons 1660-1690*, *The House of Commons 1690-1715*, and *The House of Commons, 1715-1754*. Each of these was originally published as a multi-volume set of bound books.⁴ I accessed these biographies from their online publications, web-scraped them, and compiled them into a new dataset HPP (2013).

The HPP was an endeavor begun in the interwar period, and revived in the mid-20th century. Since that time, hundreds of professional historians have worked on the project overseen by an editorial board of historians. The biographers have consulted national archives and local archives scattered throughout the UK (and sometimes abroad) along with secondary sources in order to research each individual MP and write their biography. The project professes to be “unparalleled in the comprehensiveness of its treatment...[and] regarded as one of the most ambitious, authoritative and well-researched projects in British history.” The project has been funded since the mid-1990s by the UK Parliament.

The first volumes (covering the period 1715-1754) were published in 1970. The next biographies were published in the 1980s (covering the period 1558-1603, and the period 1660-1690). The biographies covering the period 1690-1715 were published in 2002. The biographies covering the 1604-1629 period were published in 2010. As this evidences, the volumes were not researched in linear time.

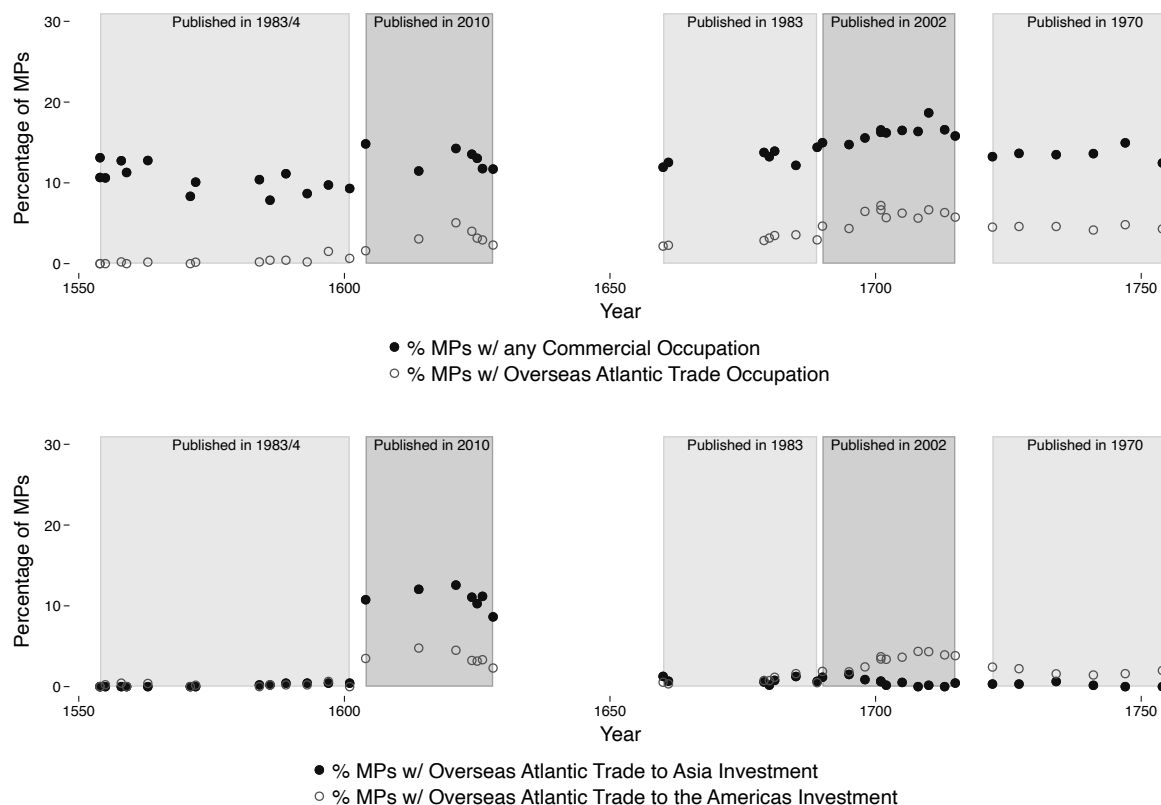
Figure C1 presents the major trends in occupation and investment presented in the paper overlaid with the periods that the biographies were researched. In the case of occupations, there is little evidence that there are dramatic discontinuities in the series at the break points. In the early 17th century however, there is some evidence that information on company investment may have been more likely to be included in the biographies in the more recent period of research. Because of this, Appendix D describes the inclusion of Rabb data to help capture earlier overseas investment that the HPP data may miss. Moreover, there were not many companies available for investment in the late 16th century as joint stock and regulated companies were just beginning. And as the main paper notes, after the Restoration, trade was de-regulated and there were few remaining investment opportunities for MPs.

The primary component of an individual MP’s biography is a narrative text describing characteristics of the MP, characteristics of his family, his social and political relationships, and various activities that he engaged in during his life, primarily political, but in other areas as well.⁵ These texts frequently describe the economic activities in which the MP was engaged. The length and detail of the biographies varies significantly, although not

⁴In total, covering periods beyond those listed here, the HPP has published 21,000 biographies in more than 20,000 pages.

⁵There were no female MPs during the period of study.

Figure C1: Trends in commercial occupations and investments and the period of HPP research



Notes: This figure presents trends in occupations and investments in commerce seen in the main table. Overlaid is information on when the research was conducted for the biographies in each section.

all biographies mention MPs' economic activities, most do.⁶ The biographies sometimes mention investments; however, conversations with scholars at the HPP indicated that investments were not a systematic focus of biographers.

In order to code the economic activities of MPs based on these biographies, I developed a natural language processing (NLP) routine; specifically an iterated dictionary classification. I use this generalized routine because it was not feasible with the time and resources available to read and code all of the biographies by hand.

The seven steps of this routine are outlined briefly below, and then described subsequently in more detail.

The routine

1. Identifies key terms (primarily individual words, but also some n -grams) by hand-coding economic interests from a sub-sample (training sample) of biographies;
2. Identifies exclusionary terms (n -grams) from the same training sample of biographies;
3. Restricts the sample of biographical content to the first paragraph of multi-paragraph biographies;

⁶Of further note, the biographies were written in stages, and published in printed volumes beginning in the 1970s (later compiled in digital format and posted online). In the regression specifications, Parliament start-year fixed effects also address concerns that common year shocks, namely biography publication dates and what they imply about historical resources available to the biographers, are not driving the results.

4. Counts non-excluded key terms by interest category (there is a one-to-one mapping between key term and interest category) in the remaining (non-training) sample of biographies;
5. Assign MPs to an interest category designed to capture whether MPs were *at all* involved in a given economic activity;
6. Validates the above machine coding by hand coding and checking the agreement on a new sub-sample (validation sample) of biographies;
7. Iterates steps 1-6 multiple times on newly drawn sub-samples of biographies to improve the key term and exclusionary term dictionary and improve the agreement between the machine coding and hand coding.

Finally, I supplement this automated routine by using any available information from the Appendices of the History of Parliament Project biographies to assign MPs to economic interests when the Appendices contain this information. Some volumes will list the names of MPs involved in particular interests or activities. I now describe each of these above steps in more detail.

Step 1: Key term dictionary

I constructed a randomly drawn first training sample of 2% of the biographies. I read the biographies in the training sample, hand-coded the economic interest(s) of the MP (i.e. my subjective interpretation of their interests), and identified key terms (words and n -grams; that is, words and strings of words) that I considered indicative of that economic activity. I compiled these key terms into a dictionary that relates key terms to interest categories in a one-to-one mapping (i.e. each key term is associated with only one interest category).⁷

The economic interest categories that I use are the following. However, because the paper is primarily interested in the commercial interests, the NLP was primarily refined in the service of best coding the distinction between commercial versus not commercial, and secondarily, the types of commercial interest.

Interest categories

1. Commercial
 - (a) Merchant Adventurers
 - (b) Asia and Middle East (Levant)
 - (c) American (Americas and Caribbean, incl. slave traders)
 - (d) Bankers and financiers
 - (e) All other
2. Industrial
 - (a) Textiles
 - (b) Mining
 - (c) All other (misc.)
3. Military
4. Professional
5. Lawyer
6. Civil Service and Courtiers
7. Farmer

Notably, I do *not* code MPs as landed. The prevalence of land ownership was so pronounced

⁷Some interest categories were further broken down into finer grained interest categories. For instance, commercial MPs could be coded as American merchants, Asia merchants, and so forth.

during this period that most MPs were not described explicitly in their biographies as landowners. Using other sources, I ascertained that many MPs whose biographies made no explicit mention of land ownership were in fact land owners. Example terms and the interest categories that they correspond to are presented in Table C1.

Broadly speaking, the commercial interest captures individuals involved in domestic and international commerce—both local shopkeepers and tradesmen, as well as those who owned ships or engaged in long-distance or overseas trade. The industrial interest attempts to capture individuals involved in production—textile manufacturing, metallurgy, glassmaking.

The military interest captures those individuals whose career activities involved service in the armed forces. The professional category includes individuals who practiced another skilled profession, primarily in the medical fields, though a small handful of architects, writers, and historians were also present. Many MPs had some involvement with the legal institutions of the day (Grey’s Inn, Middle Temple, etc.) which were often used as a finishing school for upper class families, many others spent their entire careers studying and practicing law. The lawyer category captures both types of individuals. The civil service/courtier category captures those individuals who primarily spent their careers in national government either in the royal household or other institutions. Finally, a very few farmers and yeoman who rose to become MPs are captured in the farmer category.

Table C1: Interest categories and example dictionary key term correspondence

Commercial	Industrial	Military	Professional	Lawyer
merchant, privateer, shipping, grocer, brewer, financier	glassworks, draper, furnace, tin, mill, wool	naval, army, major_general, regiment, officer, captain	poet, pathologist, architect, doctor	middle_temple, grays_inn, barrister, lawyer, solicitor, the_bar

Notes: Capitalization, plural, gerunds, and other grammatical variations are included for each key term used in the analysis. I exclude the agriculture and courtier categories for space.

A one-to-one mapping between key terms and interests means that for some terms there is some ambiguity about which interest the term better maps onto. For instance, “merciers” were traders in textiles, but the term was also sometimes used to refer to those who manufactured textiles. By and large the difficult codes are between industry and commerce. For other interests, it was not so challenging to map the key terms to the interest.

Step 2: Exclusionary term dictionary

There are many terms (mostly n -grams and longer phrases) that are irrelevant to an MP’s economic activity but which would be captured by the key term dictionary were it not for the creation of an exclusion dictionary. As an example, a mention of the East India Company could refer to an MP who was a trader or stock owner in the company. But it could also refer to a non-involved MP’s position on a bill related to the company, or the activities of a friend or fellow MP who was involved in the company, and so on. While interesting, such references do not indicate the economic activity of the MP.

The exclusion dictionary captures phrases that include dictionary key terms, but which do not indicate an MP’s economic activity. I remove these phrases from consideration when

coding the MP's activity.

Step 3: Restriction of biography text

The narrative text biographies of the HPP vary in length, but tend to follow similar organizational patterns that aid in locating the parts of the text most likely to refer to the MP's economic interest. For example, many biographies contain short references to the economic activities of MPs' family members, particularly their father. Fathers and sons often engaged in highly correlated activities, but this was not exclusively the case. The economic activities of relatives are most likely to be mentioned in the first sentence of an MP's biography. Therefore, I exclude the first sentence of the biography if it references the MP's family.⁸

I also restrict the interest coding to the first paragraph of multi-paragraph biographies. Economic interest information is rarely conveyed in later paragraphs. These later paragraphs instead usually document votes, legislative speeches, or other activity in Parliament where key terms are more likely to occur in contexts that should be in the exclusion dictionary.

Step 4: Word counts

I count whether there is more than one non-excluded dictionary key terms for each interest category in each biography. Note that although there is a one-to-one mapping between key terms and interest categories, I count key terms for MPs for all interest categories. MPs can therefore be part of multiple interest categories.

Step 5: Assign MPs to primary interest category

I assign MPs to an economic interest category if one or more key words indicate their involvement. MPs can be involved in multiple activities.⁹

Step 6: Validate the coding

I validate the coding by randomly drawing a validation sample from the the non-training sample, hand-coding the interests, and then noting the number of discrepancies between my hand-coding of the interest and the coding of the NLP routine. The source of errors in

⁸I only retain the first sentence if it refers to the MP's family if there is also reference to "inheritance," as this often indicates that the MP carried on in similar activity to the relative.

⁹I do not use the frequency of word counts to infer the primary interest an MP was involved in for a number of reasons. First, I consider the word count frequency to be a very noisy signal of the primary activity of the MP. In email conversations with HPP editors, I learned about how biographies were written and what information was included and excluded. There was no indication made in these conversations that biographers were instructed to make clear which of multiple economic interests an MP was involved in. The economic interest information was not in fact a priority for biographers at all. (Activity in Parliament was the primary goal.) Therefore, whether one activity was written about more than another may simply reflect the idiosyncratic interests of the biographer. Moreover, the word counts for different activities may reflect the availability of information about particular activities which may be more or less likely to survive for reasons unrelated to how involved the MP was in the activity. It's also not clear how to think about the primary activity of the MP. Is it time spent in the activity? Resources derived? The biographies are not sufficiently detailed to give clues here. Finally, as noted previously, I consider the concept of greatest substantive interest to be whether an MP was at all involved in a particular expanding activity *at all*.

the validation was usually exclusionary terms that were not present in the training data rather than key terms that I had not previously included in the key term dictionary.

Step 7: Iterate the process

In implementing this routine, I noticed low accuracy in the first validation round. This was largely a function of exclusionary terms that were not picked up in the first hand-coding of key terms and exclusionary terms. To account for this, I iterated the routine multiple times by drawing new samples of training biographies to code (although fewer than the initial sample each time), adding to the key term and exclusionary term dictionaries, re-coding the interests, and re-validating on a new random sample.

Using additional information for coding MPs

In addition to the NLP routine, I use an additional source of information from the History of Parliament Project to hard-code the interests of a select set of MPs. The HPP volumes contain what they refer to as a “survey” that provides some limited descriptive statistics about the information contained in that volume’s biographies.¹⁰ For some years, this information describes the counts of MPs engaged in banking, commerce, and industry and sometimes explicitly mentions the names of MPs engaged in each activity. I use this survey information to directly assign MPs to a given economic interest regardless of the word counts under the assumption that the survey information is more accurate than the NLP routine.

¹⁰The contents of these surveys varies substantially from volume to volume.

D Measuring Trade by Geography and Active Involvement

In this section I describe in more detail how I define the two main realms of new trade in the Atlantic economy—the eastern trade to Asia and the western trade to the Americas. I also describe the correspondence between the two sources of indirect involvement in trade.

Defining the Two Realms of Trade

I use Asia trade to refer to new trades to the east begun in the 16th and 17th centuries. These trades were designed to find new means of supplying largely known commercial products from Asia that had typically entered England via trade with the Low countries. These trades included those with Russia (a new way of accessing caravan routes that had typically ended in Antwerp), the Turkey trade, Levant trade, and the East India trade (including Persian trade, Indonesian trade, etc.).

The companies in the Eastward Asia trade, as I define it, for which I find MP involvement are the, are the: Eastland Company, Muscovy (Russia) Company, Barbary Company, Turkey Company, Levant Company, and the East India Company.¹¹ The Levant and East India by far comprise the largest share. One might consider the Venice company here too. The results are not sensitive to these smaller (and earlier) trading company inclusion/exclusion.

Although the South Sea Company was organized to trade between the eastward and westward realms, the fact that traders never actively participated in this company leads me to exclude it from the occupational measure of trade. I do, however, include this trade in the investment measure. Although ultimately a vehicle for government debt that generated a speculative bubble, the major organizers and investors did have a mercantile interest in the venture (Dickson, 2016).

I use Americas trade to refer to new trades with the Caribbean, North America, and occasionally, South American continent. These trades were by far the newest of all during the 15th and 16th centuries, representing the exploitation of a world that was new to Europeans. These trades had a myriad of initial motivations including finding passage to existing supplies of luxury goods in Asia via an alternative route, settlement, plantation agriculture, search for specie and other raw materials, and more. The Caribbean and Southern American colonies eventually settled into a system of plantation agriculture producing sugar, tobacco and other cash crops for England. While the Northern American colonies were outlets for settlement, particularly of religious dissidents, and a source of other minor commodities. Of course, the colonies were also a crucial source of demand for English manufactured goods. And they were a crucial source of demand for labor in the form of African slaves as well.

The companies that I classify in the Americas trade include those involved in the African slave trade (e.g., Royal Africa, Senegal, etc. Companies), the North American colonizing companies (e.g., the Virginia, Providence Island, Baffin, etc. Companies), and the Caribbean companies (e.g., Bermuda, Barbados, etc.). While the inclusion of some com-

¹¹See Willan (1968) on the relative newness of the Baltic trade in the late 16th century via the Muscovy Company. The Eastland trade might be more controversial but contributes little to any of the results of the paper.

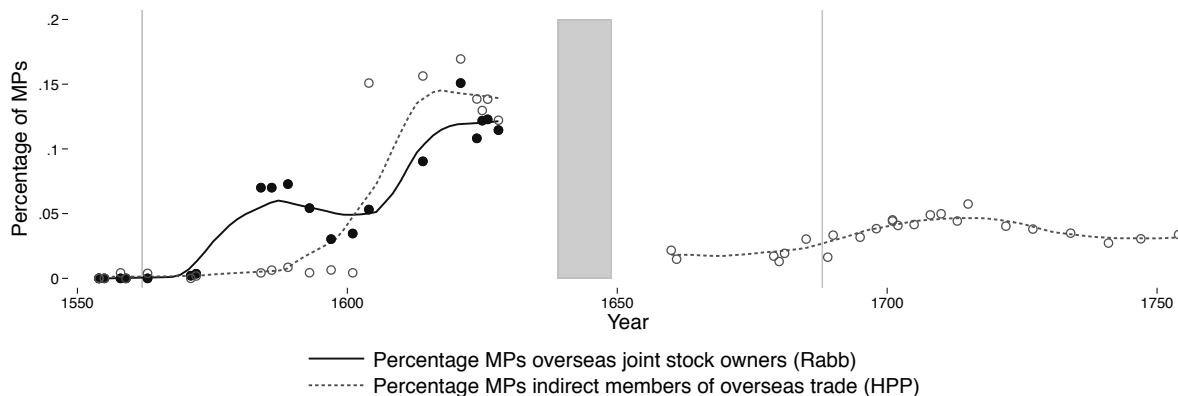
panies like the Eastland or Venice in the Asia trade requires some motivation, the coding lines for the American companies are much clearer. The only exception might be those companies involved in trade with Africa. But given the importance of the slave trade for those companies (even if they began by searching for other import or export markets), they seem best classified as involved in the western trades.

Not all companies (or the merchants actively trading in them) are classified as part of either Asian or American trade. Some companies like the French or Spanish are included only in the calculation of all overseas trading companies, or as indicating an MP was a merchant, generally speaking. These companies were new and part of a commercial expansion during the era, but they were not really new *trades* that resulted from technological shocks of the era (Davis, 1973). Rabb explicitly notes that companies like the French and Spanish were “not really central to England’s expansion” in trade during this period (Rabb, 1967, 54).

Sources of Indirect Involvement in Overseas Trade

There are two sources of data on indirect involvement in overseas trade. The offices section of the HPP biographies are the first. These mention memberships, directorships and governorships in overseas trading companies. The second is Rabb (1967) who collects data on joint-stock ownership in the major overseas trading companies (and others) for the period 1558-1630. Below I demonstrate a general agreement in the two sources in the proportion of MPs who are indirectly involved in overseas trade via membership or joint-stock investment in the companies.

Figure D1: Trends in MP inactive involvement in overseas trade by source



Notes: The plot presents the percentage of MPs coded as invested (inactively involved) in overseas trade from two sources: the HPP, and Rabb (1967).

As I note in the main text of the paper, I use an *inclusive* measure for the main analysis of the paper. If either Rabb or the HPP biographies links an MP to overseas trade, I code that MP as indirectly involved. This coding choice is made because I perceive differences to arise because of how the sources chose to code, rather than fundamental differences in the quality of information. For example, the HPP describes MP Henry Anderson (Newcastle-on-Tyne) as involved in the Turkey trade and the Levant company, but the offices section of his biography does not list him as a “member” of the Turkey company (or otherwise a

shareholder).¹² Rabb on the other hand does list him as an owner of joint stock.

The Rabb data ends in 1630. Despite the general agreement between the HPP data and the Rabb data, it is possible that the lack of an explicit data source for post-1630 joint stock ownership biases the analysis for this period. Though it is important to note that the heyday of the corporate overseas trades was prior to the English Civil War, and thus, having complimentary sources for this period is the most important. Many of these companies went bankrupt or had their privileges revoked, if not their charters dissolved entirely prior to the Restoration (Davies, 1952; Rabb, 1967; Jha, 2015).

Figure D2 presents the general trends in commercial MPs excluding the Rabb data from the pre-1630 in order to rely on only one source that is comparable across periods. I find that the most striking difference in the results comes in indirect investment to Asia. The pattern of the trend is the same as that presented in the paper, but is smaller in magnitude. This suggests (as does Figure D1), that the Rabb data is able to identify investors in the Asia trade that are missed in the HPP data.

I examine this by considering a sample of MPs that are not coded as investors (in a given trade) by my coding of the HPP data, but which are investors in the Rabb data. I confirm that my coding routine is not missing mentions in the HPP data, but that Rabb has more data. In explicitly using the joint stock ledgers, Rabb likely had access to investors who, through their other activities, did not leave a trace of their investments that the HPP would have found. Through conversations with the historians at the HPP, I learned that joint-stock ownership was not an explicit source of inquiry for those who wrote the biographies.

Beyond the number of MPs who invested in trade, Grassby (1995) and Rabb (1967) estimate that there were around 4,000 merchant subscribers during the pre-1630 period. These figures are estimates, as it is difficult to account for the sale of stocks. But, per Appendix I, they indicate that about 4 times as many individuals invested in trade as actively participated, far more so if you consider only those involved in overseas trade, or overseas traders of wealth or consequence.

¹²<http://www.historyofParliamentonline.org/volume/1558-1603/member/anderson-henry-1545-1605>.

Figure D2: Trends in merchants in Parliament using only HPP data, 1550-1750



Sources: Author's calculations based on data from HPP (2013).

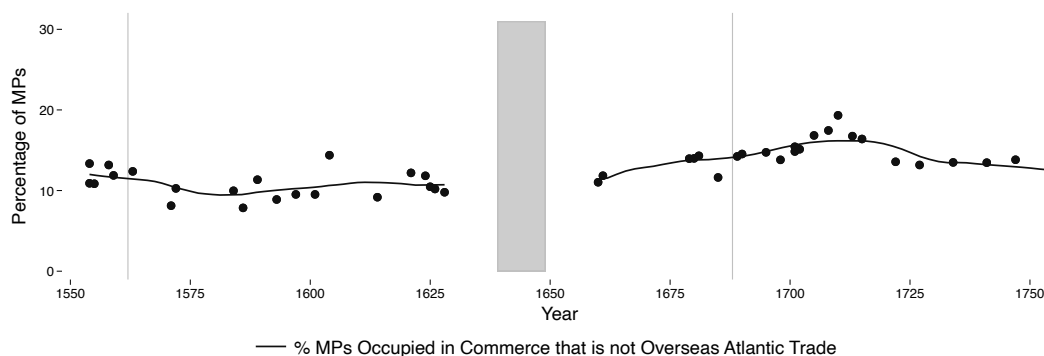
Notes: The top plot presents trends in each MPs occupied in commerce in Parliament, relative to those who are members of overseas trading companies. The middle plot presents these trends for those involved in eastward trade to Asia (whether occupied or investor). The bottom plot presents these for those involved in westward trade to the Americas (whether occupied or investor). The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and a gray vertical line at 1688 indicates the Glorious Revolution. I exclude pre-1630 data from Rabb (1967).

E Additional Trends in MP Characteristics

In this appendix I present additional parliament-wide trends for MPs.

Although the historical evidence suggests that the economic change wrought by the Atlantic economy was hardly unique to those moving goods overseas—transforming wholesale and retail commerce as well—Figure E1 indicates that those MPs representing trades other than Asian and American commerce did not increase their representation over the long 17th century.

Figure E1: Trends in non-Asia non-Americas merchants in Parliament, 1550-1750



Sources: Author's calculations based on data from HPP (2013) and Rabb (1967).

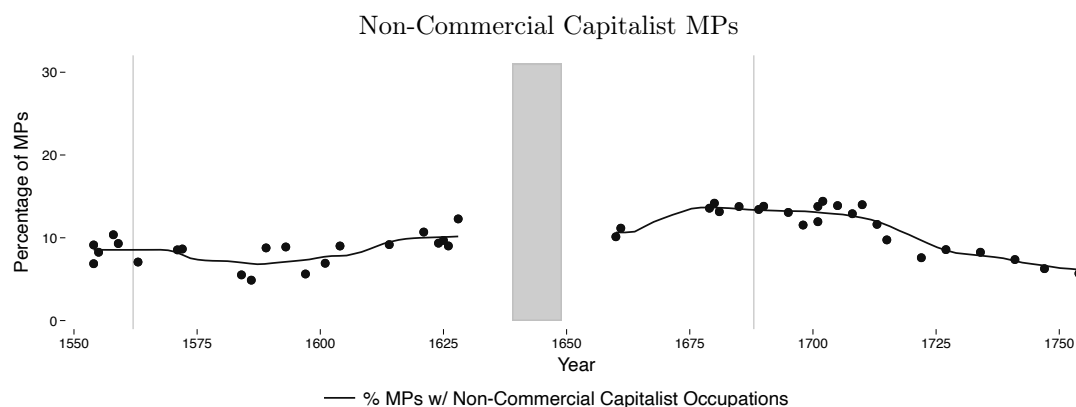
Notes: The English Civil War is shaded in gray, and a gray vertical lines denote each the first sailing of an English slave ship, and the Glorious Revolution.

In the plots in the paper, I focus on commerce MPs as compared to capitalist MPs because the historical evidence attributes the most significant effects of trade to sectors rather than factors of production, more broadly. In this appendix, I demonstrate that non-commercial capitalists increased their representation in Parliament from about 9% in the late 16th century to 15% a century later. This change came in the same steady growth as those actively involved in commerce. Like with commerce, their representation declined just after 1700, though non-commercial capitalists more so than active commercial men. Taken together, these results suggest that as commerce increased in response to the opening of trade, so too did the representation of non-commercial capitalist interests in Parliament. But in both cases, representation was modest.

MPs with surname connections to an MP from the pre-1550 period declined very gradually over the period, far more indicative of the death of family lineages than of a shift in the social bases of representational power brought about by trade.

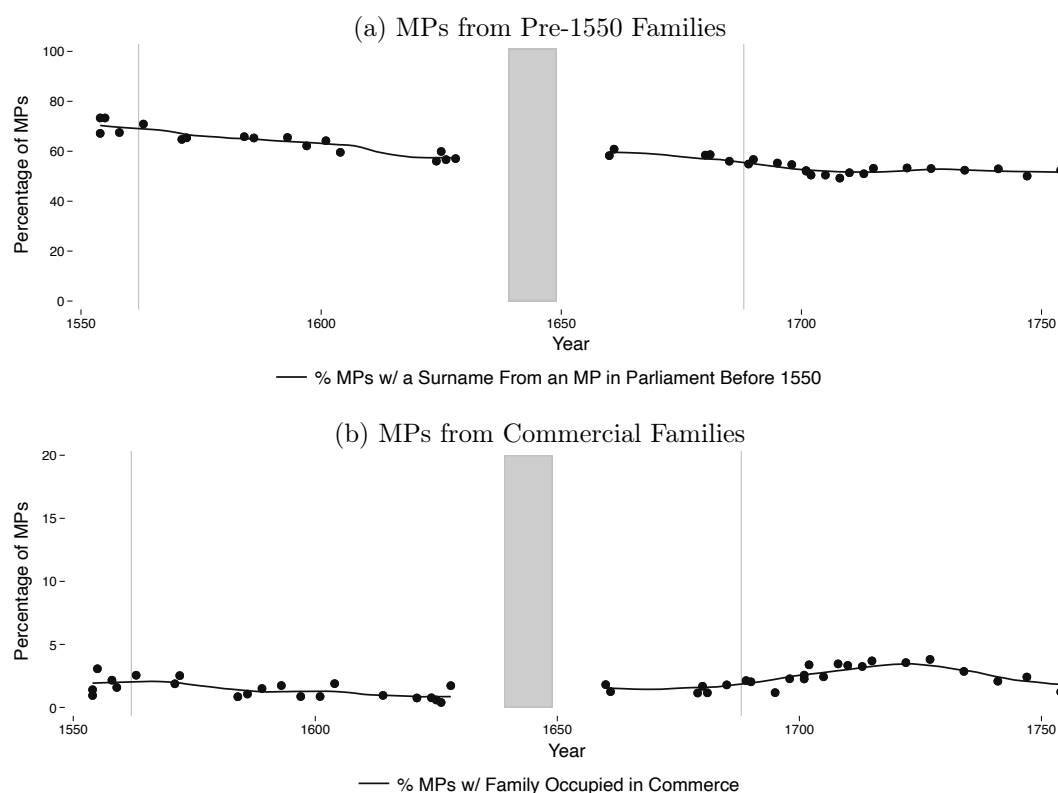
Plot (d) of Figure E3 demonstrates that MPs with commercial families were stable throughout the period. Thus, it's not the case that the wealth of commerce made its significant impact in parliament beyond the first generation. I code an MP as having a commercial family (whether or not they were in Parliament) from two parts of the biography: *i*) the "Family and Education" section, or *ii*) the first sentence of the narrative text, which is most likely to discuss "family" (if indeed it does mention key terms related to the family, e.g., "family," "father," etc.) Even into the 19th century, so-called "new men," whose wealth

Figure E2: Trends in the parliamentary representation of non-commercial capital



Notes: The plot presents trends in non-commercial capitalists (aggregating those in textile production, mining, other manufacturing, banking and (non-legal) professions like doctors and architects).

Figure E3: Trends in social and family backgrounds of MPs, 1550-1750



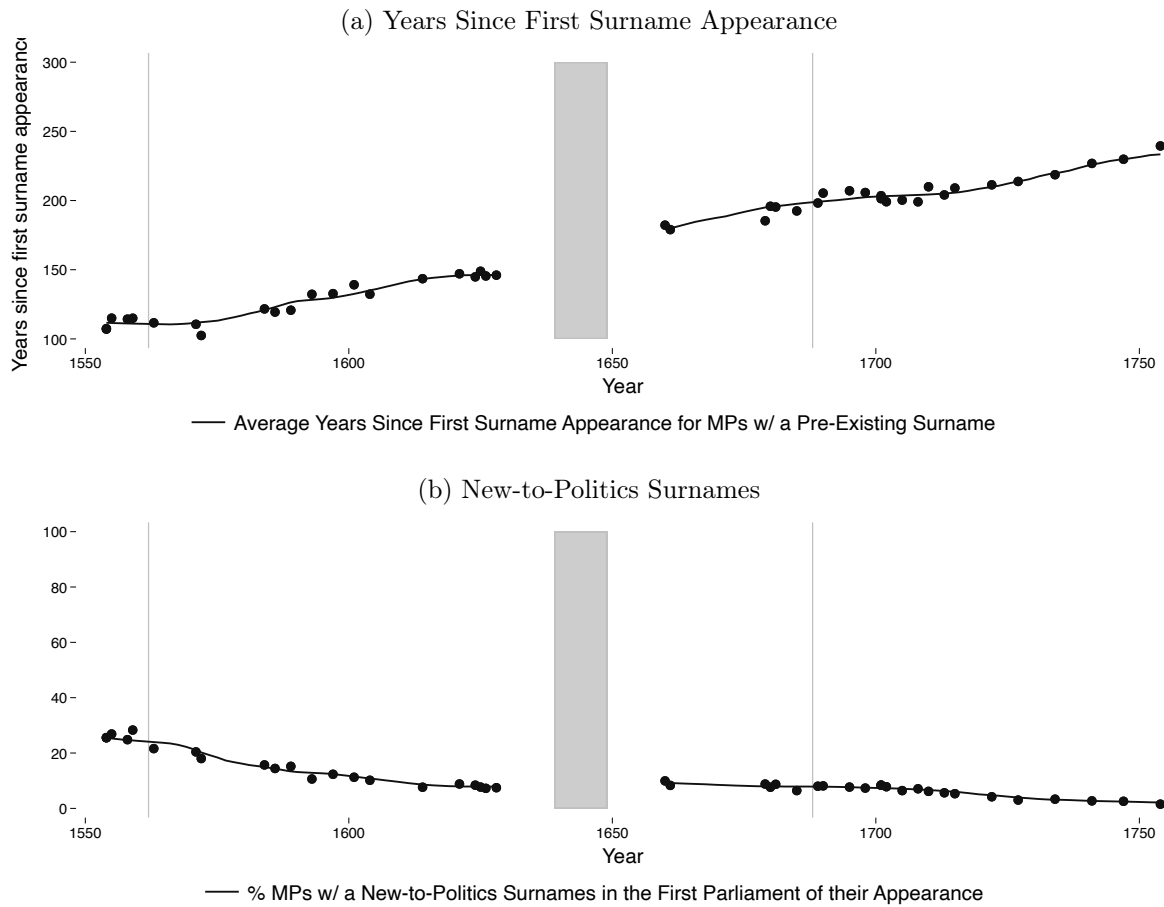
Sources: Author's calculations based on data from HPP (2013).

Notes: The plots present trends in MPs who are: (a) from a family in Parliament pre-1550 (England only); (b) from a merchant family (note: not necessarily a Parliamentary merchant family). In all plots, the English Civil War is shaded in gray, and a gray vertical lines denote each the first sailing of a English slave ship, and the Glorious Revolution. The y-axis of the plots are different.

did not originate from a landed estate, sought to acquire land and the social status that it entailed.¹³ This pattern strongly suggests that commercial wealth did not obtain its

¹³The mild, but not insignificant “distaste” amongst the the landed elite for those engaged in trade was a persistent front of domestic social tension (Gauci, 2001). The “migration of rich merchants to the countryside and younger sons to the towns” was an important intergenerational mechanism through which the background of the landed elite slowly transformed (Rabb, 1967). It's worth noting that Lang (1974)

Figure E4: Trends in the social and political backgrounds of MPs, 1550-1750



Notes: The above plot presents the trends in the average number of years since a given surname first appeared in parliament amongst MPs in a given parliament (plot a). The lower plot (b) presents the percentage of MPs in a given parliament with a surname that has never before been observed in politics. The gray shading represents the English Civil War, and the vertical lines the first sailing of English-flagged slave ship, and the Glorious Revolution.

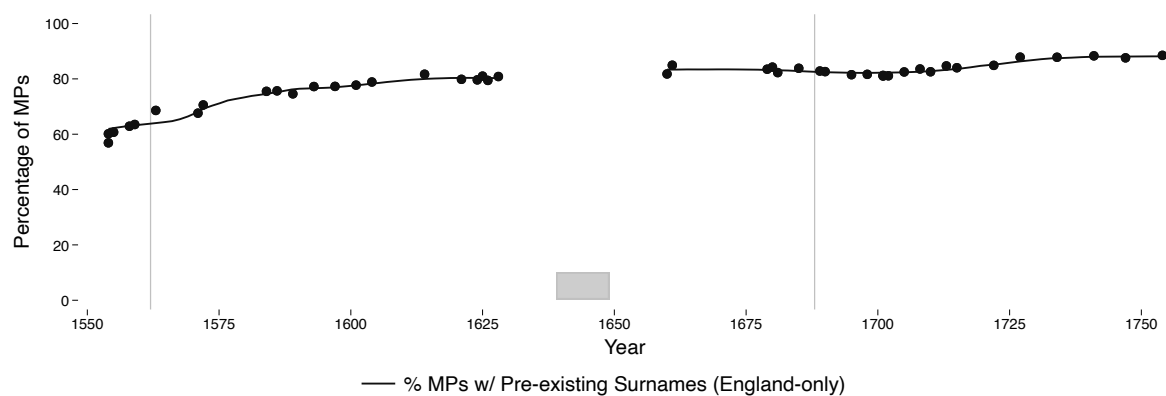
political importance differentially it was filtered through other sources of political power, like land.

In Figure E5 I present the trends in pre-existing surnames separated by nation—England and Wales. In England, I am able to connect surnames back to 1386, ensuring that low surname connections in the early period that I study are not simply a function of a lack of data. When I make these connections for Wales, however, I am constrained by the fact that Wales only joined Great England in 1536. Figure E5 suggests that there is more volatility in the shared surnames of Welsh MPs in the late 16th and early 17th centuries (there are also dramatically fewer parliamentary seats, and thus MPs in Wales). Despite this, the general trend and magnitude of the values comparable.

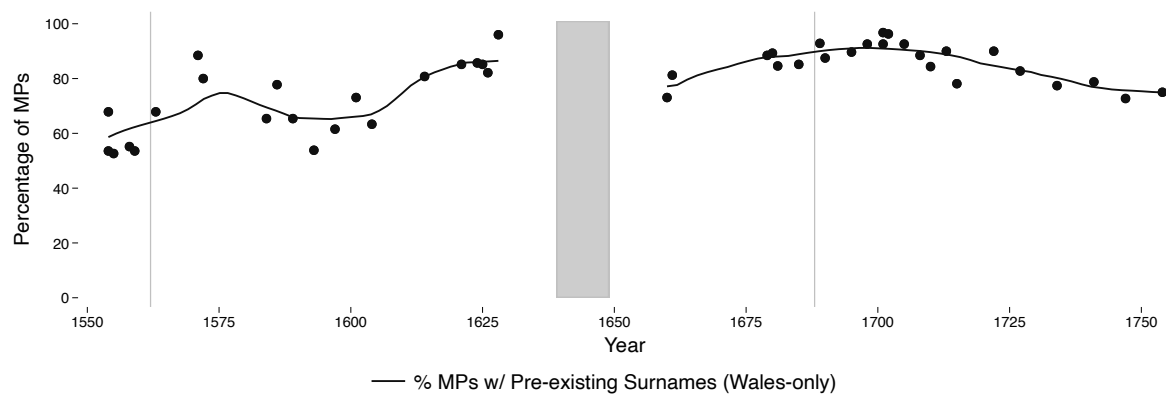
complicates this view that merchants always engaged in this circulation of wealth into land, noting that while many purchased estates, they often retained their foothold in commerce and in the cities that engaged in it.

Figure E5: Trends in pre-existing surnames by nation, 1550-1750

(a) Within-England Pre-Existing Surnames, England-only



(b) Within-Wales Pre-Existing Surnames, Wales-only

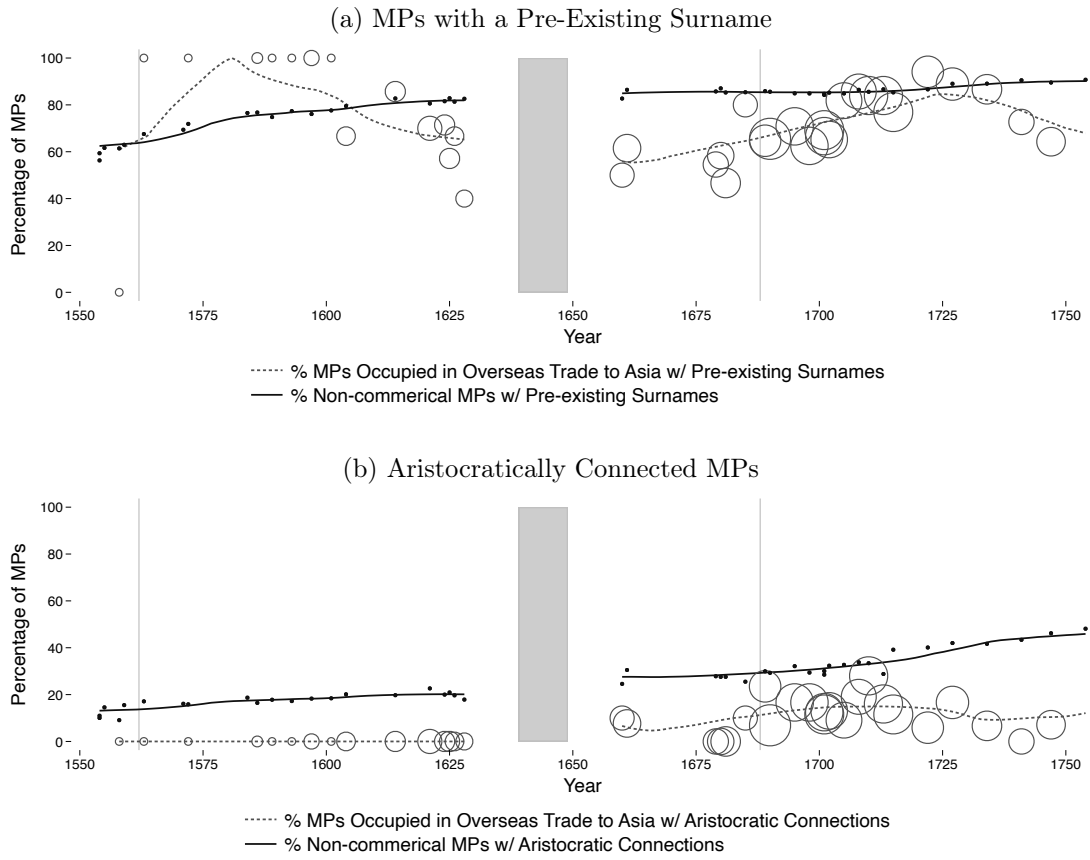


Notes: The above plot presents the trends for pre-existing surnames separated by nation. I can connect political dynasties in England before 1550 going back to 1386. In Wales, the age of the nation constrains the connections to 1536. The gray shading represents the English Civil War, and the vertical lines the first sailing of English-flagged slave ship, and the Glorious Revolution.

F Additional Trends in Commercial MP Characteristics

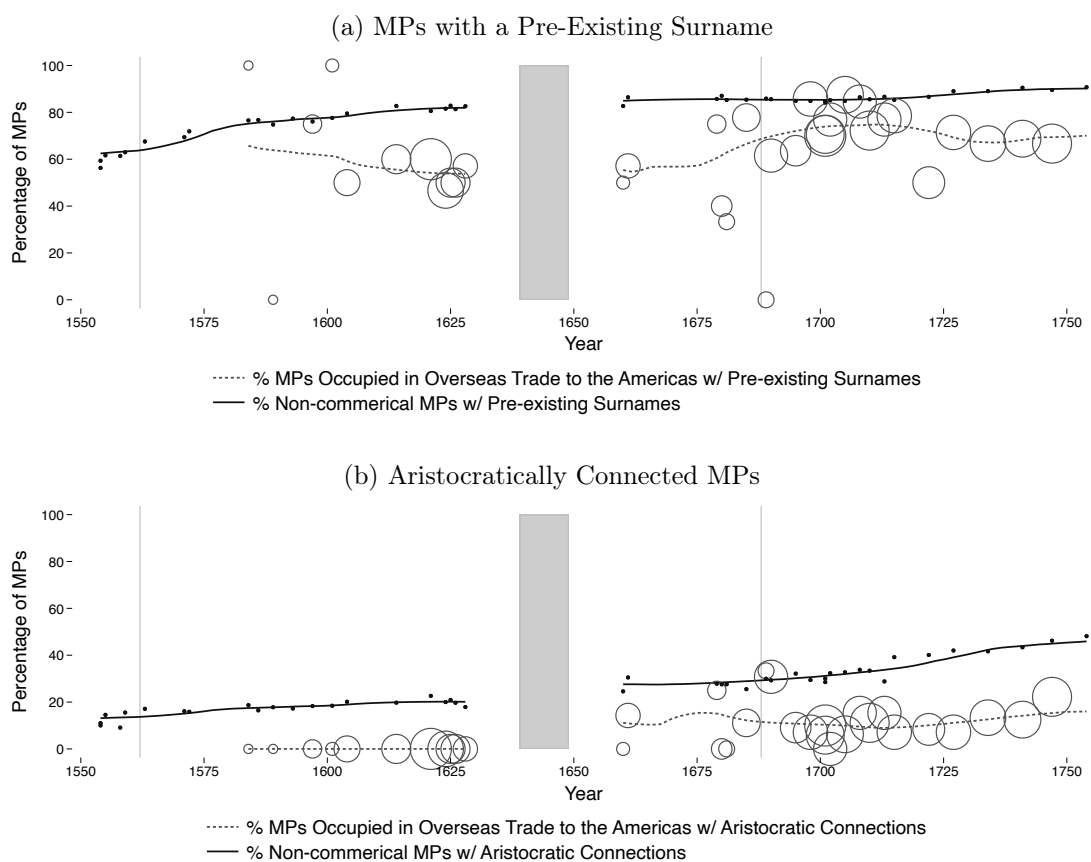
In this appendix, I present additional trends that focus on the difference in socio-familial background characteristics of various categories of commercial MPs. In all plots, the comparison of commercial MPs is relative to non-commercial MPs.

Figure F1: Difference in socio-familial backgrounds of MPs occupied in overseas Atlantic trade to Asia versus non-commercial MPs



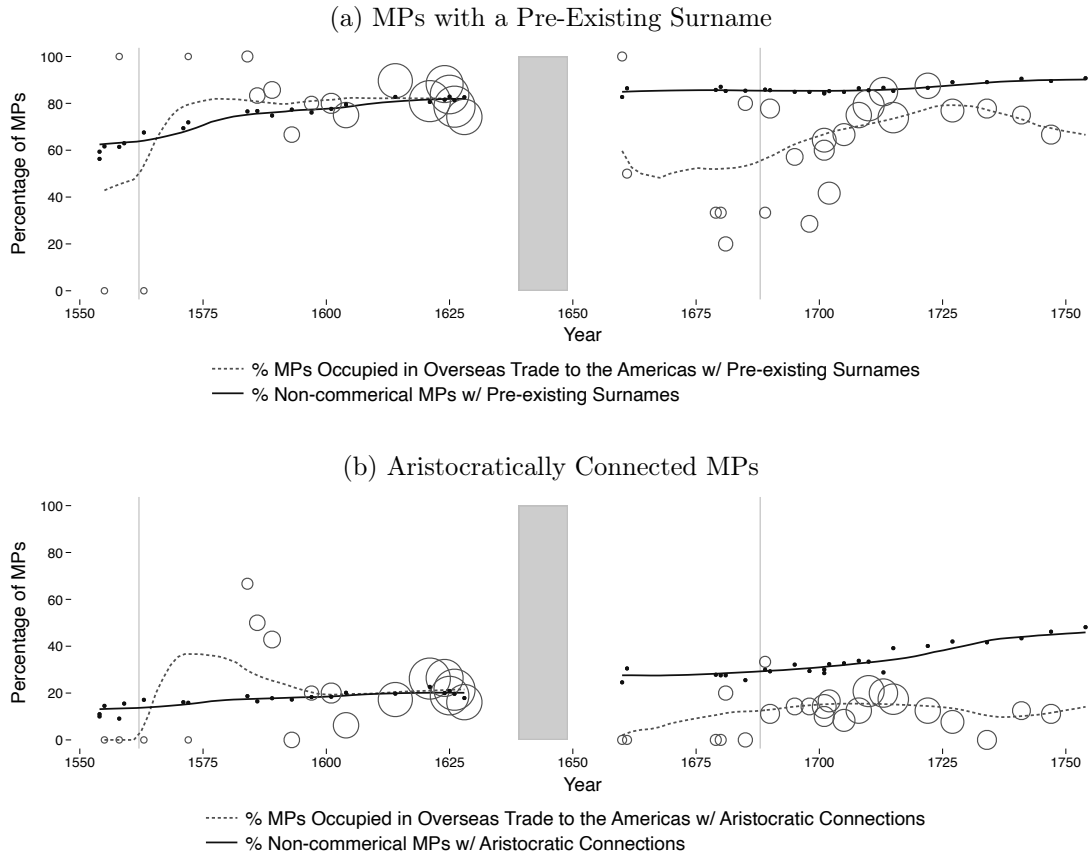
Notes: The plots show the share of MPs with overseas Atlantic trade to Asia interests who share a surname with a pre-existing MP (plot a), or who have a family connection to the hereditary aristocracy (plot b). For comparative context, the same trends are also plotted for non-commercial MPs (solid black line). The size of the hollow circles for MPs with trade interests is proportional to the number of trade interested MPs in a given parliament. The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and gray vertical lines indicate the first sailing of a British-flagged slave ship (1562) and the Glorious Revolution settlement (1688).

Figure F2: Difference in socio-familial backgrounds of MPs occupied in overseas Atlantic trade to the Americas versus non-commercial MPs



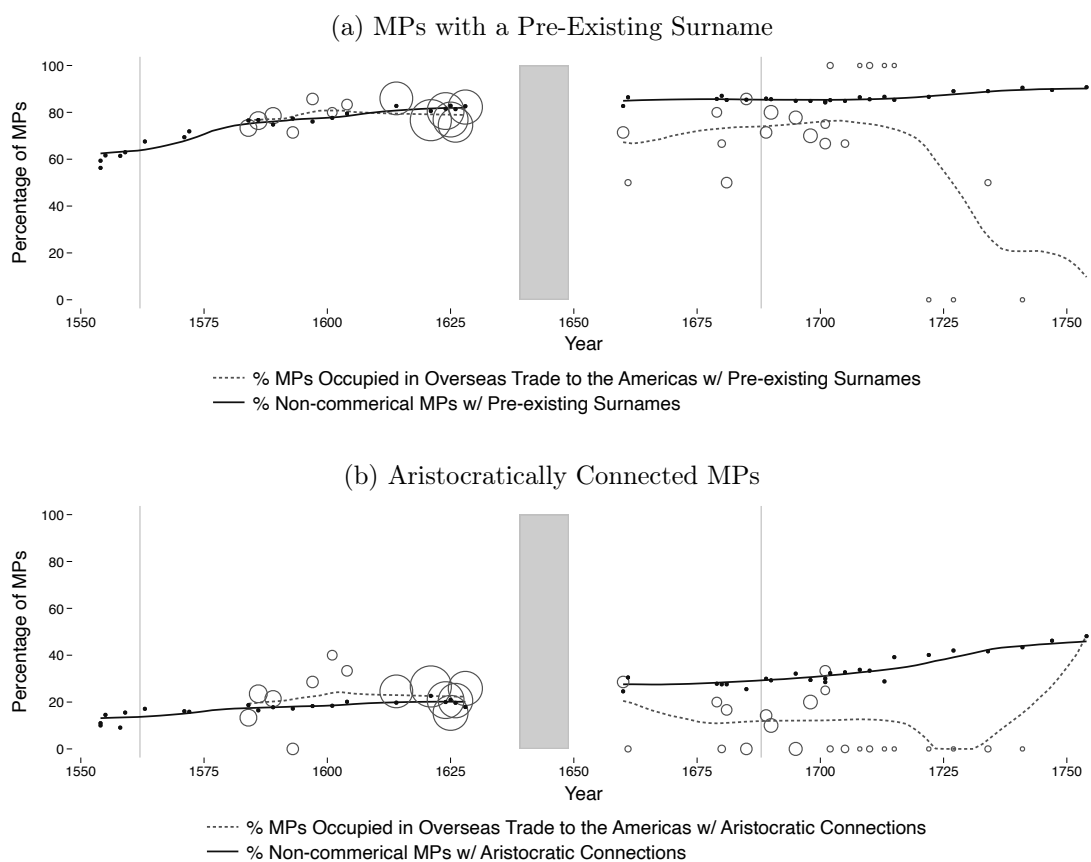
Notes: The plots show the share of MPs with overseas Atlantic trade to the Americas interests who share a surname with a pre-existing MP (plot a), or who have a family connection to the hereditary aristocracy (plot b). For comparative context, the same trends are also plotted for non-commercial MPs (solid black line). The size of the hollow circles for MPs with trade interests is proportional to the number of trade interested MPs in a given parliament. The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and gray vertical lines indicate the first sailing of a British-flagged slave ship (1562) and the Glorious Revolution settlement (1688).

Figure F3: Difference in socio-familial backgrounds of MPs invested in overseas Atlantic trade to Asia versus non-commercial MPs



Notes: The plots show the share of MPs with overseas Atlantic trade to Asia investments who share a surname with a pre-existing MP (plot a), or who have a family connection to the hereditary aristocracy (plot b). For comparative context, the same trends are also plotted for non-commercial MPs (solid black line). The size of the hollow circles for MPs with trade interests is proportional to the number of trade interested MPs in a given parliament. The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and gray vertical lines indicate the first sailing of a British-flagged slave ship (1562) and the Glorious Revolution settlement (1688).

Figure F4: Difference in socio-familial backgrounds of MPs invested in overseas Atlantic trade to the Americas versus non-commercial MPs



Notes: The plots show the share of MPs with overseas Atlantic trade to the Americas investments who share a surname with a pre-existing MP (plot a), or who have a family connection to the hereditary aristocracy (plot b). For comparative context, the same trends are also plotted for non-commercial MPs (solid black line). The size of the hollow circles for MPs with trade interests is proportional to the number of trade interested MPs in a given parliament. The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and gray vertical lines indicate the first sailing of a British-flagged slave ship (1562) and the Glorious Revolution settlement (1688).

G The Parliamentary Activity of Commercial MPs

As I describe in the main text, a Parliamentary seat was valued for two broad reasons. First, it was a marker of social status; confirming the relative social importance of an MP in their constituency, or county more generally. Second, it was politically instrumental, both in terms of personal aims, and more general policies affecting the constituency or the nation as a whole. (As Thrush (2010*a*) describes: “For some, the Commons was where they might help to shape the law and influence government policy, while to others it primarily represented a refuge from clambouring creditors or an opportunity to savour the delights of the capital.”)

In this appendix, I consider whether commercial MPs were more or less likely to seek Parliamentary power for status confirmation as compared to policy aims. This helps me to understand the mechanisms—in terms of the value of a Parliamentary seat—facilitating the entry of new MPs. On the one hand, commercial men may have been more likely to seek a seat in Parliament for social status confirmation because commerce was often regarded as an inferior occupation relative to idle landownership (Gauci, 2001). In 16th and 17th century England, the social importance of landownership ensured that commercial men always sought to settle into an estate and the class that it represented. Commercial men “do creep and seek to be gentlemen” wrote one contemporary (Haslert, 2004).

Alternatively, the value of a Parliamentary seat for policy may have been greater for those involved in commerce. The changing nature of trade in England required policies tailored to it. Merchants were in the best position to advocate for those policies. Thus, they may have been some of the most active members as they attempted to shape policy for their goals.

I use the narrative text of the HPP biographies to measure the activity of MPs. I do this using a variant of the modified dictionary classification that I use to code the economic interests. Rather than look for keywords that reflect interests, I instead look for key words that indicate the relative activity of MPs in Parliament. These include references to the number of committees the MP served on, the MP’s record (or rather, lack) of speeches in debate, and the MP’s attendance in Parliament. Often the biographer summarized by labelling the MP as simply “inactive.”

I use an indicator variable to code MPs as inactive if I encounter one or more references to inactivity in the biography. Unfortunately, the biographies are not sufficiently detailed to allow me to evaluate whether MPs were more or less active depending on the constituency that they served for, nor the particular Parliament. However, in reading the biographies I did not encounter evidence that constituency-specific accountability mechanisms made MPs differentially active (or in particular, inactive when representing some constituencies and active when representing others). The evidence instead suggests that MPs tended to be active or inactive based on individual-specific characteristics.

As I’ve noted in other places in the paper, conversations with the HPP indicated that biographers were primarily tasked with researching the Parliamentary activity of MPs. In using explicit references to inactivity, I am implicitly trusting the judgement of biographers that a member was indeed inactive instead of appearing to be inactive because of a lack of availability of evidence (which might arise for other reasons). I use references of inactivity, rather than the biography length more generally, because biographies did include information beyond Parliamentary activity. Indeed, I find a low correlation between biography

length and explicit mentions of inactivity.

Table G1: Predicting MP Parliamentary inactivity with involvement in commerce

	Pr(Inactive)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Commercial (all)	-0.011 (0.0067)		
American merchant		-0.031* (0.018)	
Asia merchant			-0.052*** (0.014)
Earliest year returned	0.00040*** (0.000029)	0.00040*** (0.000029)	0.00041*** (0.000029)
Dynastic	-0.0074 (0.0055)	-0.0073 (0.0055)	-0.0074 (0.0055)
Aristocratic family	-0.0042 (0.0068)	-0.0037 (0.0067)	-0.0041 (0.0067)
Pre-1550 family	0.0042 (0.0052)	0.0045 (0.0052)	0.0043 (0.0052)
Age at first parliament	0.000020*** (0.0000030)	0.000020*** (0.0000030)	0.000020*** (0.0000030)
Number of constituencies	-0.0041* (0.0025)	-0.0041 (0.0025)	-0.0039 (0.0025)
Obsv.	9815	9815	9815
Mean of DV	0.063	0.063	0.063
SD of DV	0.24	0.24	0.24

Robust standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: The unit of analysis is the individual MP. Estimates are obtained from OLS.

Using this measure of inactivity from the biographies, I predict activity with the economic interest of MPs after accounting for other individual-specific characteristics. I focus attention on the partial correlation between inactivity and any commercial activity as well as Asia and American commerce, specifically. The unit of analysis is the MP. I account for the fact that there may be a secular trend in Parliamentary activity by accounting for the (earliest) year that the MP was returned. I also account for the fact that dynastic, aristocratic, or MPs with families in Parliament before 1550 may seek seats for particular reasons related to activity, as well as the age MPs enter Parliament, and the total number of constituencies that they serve for. I estimate the simple cross-sectional regression with OLS.

Table G1 presents the results. After accounting for other predictors of activity, commercial MPs, generally, and Asia and America merchants, specifically, are less likely to be inactive members of Parliament. These results are highly statistically significant. In terms of magnitude, commercial MPs are between 2 and 5 percentage points less likely to be inactive. If activity is evidence of seeking a Parliamentary seat for policy aims as opposed to social confirmation, these results suggest that commercial MPs were less interested in a Parliamentary seat as social status confirmation.

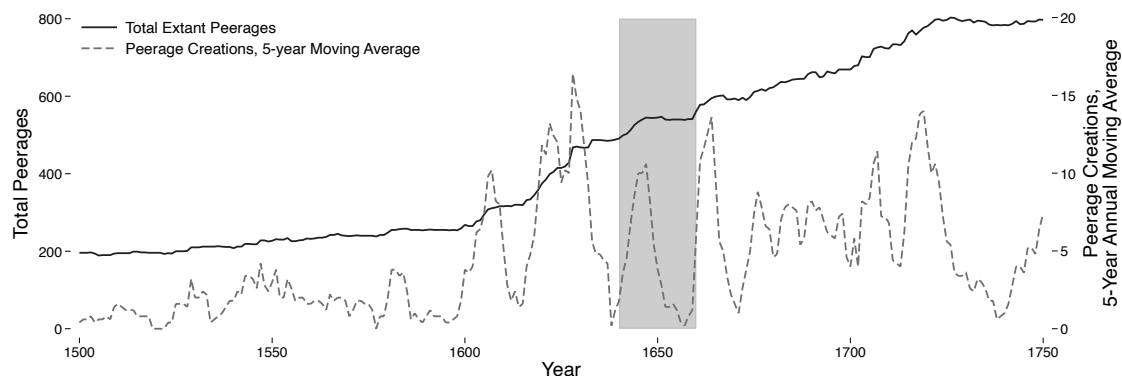
H The Size of the Peerage

In this appendix, I present trends in the size of the peerage. While political dynasties are a function of who sat in previous parliaments—which is effectively constant throughout the period that I study—the representation of peers may be a function how many peers exist. Indeed, it is well known that the Stuart monarchs used peerage creations to cultivate favor and reward loyal subjects.

In Figure H1, I present the trend average annual creation of peerages (5 year backwards looking moving average), and I present trends in extant peerages (new creations minus those that died out or were revoked by the Crown). The figure clearly demonstrates the growth in new peerages in the early 17th century.

In the paper, I present trends of the percentage of MPs with aristocratic backgrounds normalized by the size of the peerage to account for this growth.

Figure H1: Peerage Creations and Total Extant Peerages



Notes: The plot presents trends in the total extant peerages (new creations minus extinct/abeyant titles), and new peerage creations. The trends are presented for all hereditary peerage types except baronetcies.

I The Distribution of Merchants and Their Wealth in Society

Estimating the distribution of mercantile interests in society, let alone their relative wealth is an exceptionally difficult task in the long 17th century. Gauci (2001), for instance, “laments the lack of precision” in figures of this nature. Nevertheless, to provide a point of comparison for MPs in Parliament, I draw on the history that has attempted to provide these figures for various points in English history. Although far from comprehensive, I attempt to triangulate sources to provide estimates of the relative wealth and distribution of the mercantile interest in English society. The reader is urged to take these as rough estimates.¹⁴

I consider the distribution of active merchants and their wealth. I attempt to construct an estimate of commercial wealth from both before 1640 and after 1660.

Before 1688—and certainly before 1660—data on the distribution of merchants and their wealth is scarce.¹⁵ However, Grassby (1995) provides a comprehensive description of the various estimates in the extant literature. Table II summarizes a key set of these numbers. I focus on the figures Grassby provides explicitly about the pre-1660 (and ideally pre-1640 period). He provides additional figures for other towns, but it is often difficult to separate merchants from artisans, to ascertain the period, or other vagaries that lead me to exclude the figures as providing a potentially misleading picture.

In London, the major port of the period, total merchants hovered at around 1,000 throughout the pre-1640 period. Of those, approximately 150—growing to 172 at the outset of the civil war—are categorized as wealthy, with the remaining being “lesser merchants.” Bristol, the next largest port of the period, had approximately 800 merchants over the same period, although the distribution of wealthy to lesser merchants is unclear. The other outports had on the order of 100-200 merchants, though again the wealth distribution is unclear.

These figures are rough, to say nothing of their inability to adequately address the distribution of merchants between overseas trade and domestic trades, or the distribution of merchants between distinct geographic spheres of trade. Grassby provides some estimates here, but again they provide an incomplete picture. Between 1581 and 1624, he estimates that there were approximately 400 Baltic exporters. Between 1606 and 1660, he estimates about 1,300 traders to Virginia. Though he qualifies this by noting that only around 30 of those Virginia traders engaged in more than one voyage.

Grassby makes rough estimates of the wealth distribution of the mercantile class. Based on his compilation of statistics, Grassby concludes that the total number of businessmen with

¹⁴A more thorough accounting over this entire time period would certainly merit a contribution in its own right. One of the challenges for such a work is evaluating the representativeness of sources, particularly when one is interested in national figures. Most figures of the mercantile class in the literature are geographic-specific—pertaining to London only, Bristol or another outport, or a particular county. How exactly each of these places represents other locations is difficult to ascertain. Comprehensive statistics are rare. In addition, the sources of statistics vary considerably in the likelihood that they are even representative of the areas studied. These might include freeman admissions, poll taxes, poll books, hearth taxes, charity contributions, probate records, generally, and records of the Court of Orphans, among others.

¹⁵To the author’s knowledge, no comprehensive study in the vein of Lindert and Williamson’s below exists for this earlier period.

Table I1: Number of Merchants in England, pre-1640

Location	Type	Year Range	Category	Number
London	—	late 1500s	lesser merchants	850
		late 1500s	wealthy merchants	150
		1604	merchants	1,000
		1641	lesser merchants	900
		1641	wealthy merchants	172
Bristol	major outpost	1607-1651	merchants	293
		1607-1651	large-scale dealers	537
Gloucester	minor port/town	1620s-30s	merchants	70
Great Yarmouth	minor port/town	1620s-30s	merchants	196
Ipswich	minor port/town	1620s-30s	merchants	70
King's Lynn	minor port/town	1620s-30s	merchants	70
Shrewsbury	minor port/town	1608	drapers	84
		1625	drapers	113
York	major outpost	1575-1600	merchants	181

Source: Grassby (1995), pages 54-60.

Notes: The category uses the terms from Grassby. the only exception is is that I use “lesser merchants” to distinguish those from wealthy merchants. I focus only on the numbers that Grassby collects that are exclusively pre-1640, and identifiable as such (some figures are given ambiguous dates). Town categorization by Grassby.

£500 or more in assets in the main provincial towns was likely around 1,000; while 250 of those probably had capital in excess of £1,000 (58). He goes on to write that in the lesser provincial towns and countryside the total number of businessmen worth at least £500 was once again around 1,000 (58). Perhaps most usefully—and interestingly—Grassby writes that “the number of businessmen appears to have remained fairly constant for most of the [17th] century and not to have increased proportionately to the growth of foreign trade.” He summarizes the growth in England as a whole as around 800 “substantial” businessmen prior to 1630, rising to 1,000 in the 1680s, and then leveling off for the remainder of the century.¹⁶ Grassby’s definition of businessmen includes far more than overseas merchants, so we’re left to infer that such merchants would represent some fraction of this total number of businessmen. In terms of lesser businessmen (£500 or more), adding the main provincial towns (1,000), lesser provincial towns (1,000) and London (another 1,000) together results in an estimate of 3,000.

For the period after 1660, more data is available. Gregory King in *Natural and Political Observations* has the classic first estimates of the distribution of wealth in English society from 1688 (Barnett, 1936). Those were revised by others using additional data and more sophisticated inferential techniques, namely by Lindert and Williamson (1982), as the original tables have received significant critiques.¹⁷ Lindert and Williamson also augment estimates from Joseph Massie for 1759 at the end of my period of study.¹⁸ I present Lindert and Williamson’s figures for 1688 and 1759 in Table I2.

¹⁶It’s not clear, but I think it’s possible to infer that “substantial” refers to those businessmen with more

Table I2: Income and Occupation Distribution Estimates for England, 1688 and 1759

Category	1688		1759	
	Head Counts	Avg. Family Income (£)	Head Counts	Avg. Family Income (£)
High titles and skills	62,586		75,070	
Merchants (total)	128,025		200,500	
By sea (greater)	2,000	400		
By sea (lesser)	8,000	200		
By land (greater)	3,264	400		
By land (lesser)	13,057	200		
Retail	101,704	45		
Lesser merchant			600	1,000
Middle merchant			400	2,000
Wealthy merchant			200	10,000
Lesser tradesmen			400	2,500
Middle tradesmen I			200	5,000
Middle tradesmen II			100	10,000
Middle tradesmen III			70	20,000
Wealthy tradesmen			40	125,000
Innkeepers & ale-sellers			100	2,000
Innkeepers			70	3,000
Ale-sellers & cottagers (greater)			40	20,000
Industry	256,866		366,252	
Agriculture	227,440		379,008	
Military	94,000		86,000	
Laborers	621,669		432,310	
Total	1,390,586		1,539,140	

Source: Lindert and Williamson (1982)

Notes: See Lindert and Williamson for details on the categorization. The sub-categories for merchant differ between 1688 and 1759.

than £1,000.

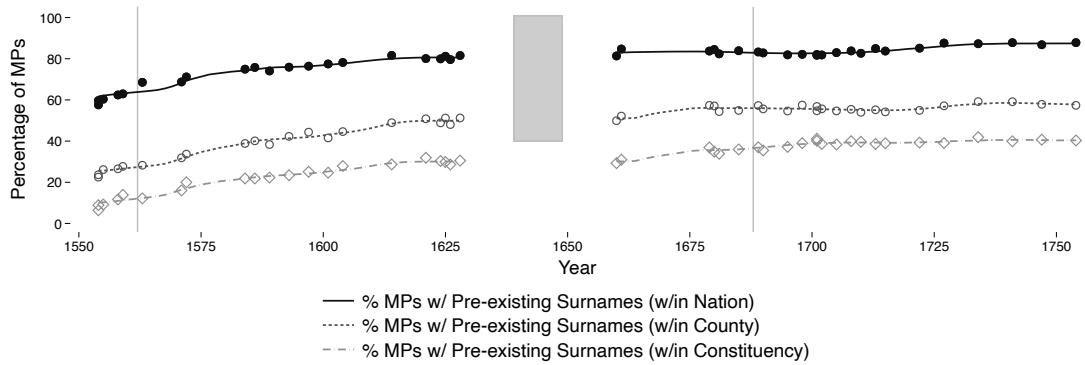
¹⁷See e.g., Holmes (1977).

¹⁸See Massie (1760) and Mathias (1957).

J Connecting Surnames within Different Geographic Bounds

The surname matches that I construct in the paper are made within nation. Under the argument that MPs are more likely to be family members (even distant ones) when they share a surname and are from the same nation (i.e., either England or Wales), I restrict surname connections in this way. Here, I present trends in surname connections with more geographically restrictive bounds—within counties and within constituencies. The substantive rationale for a geographic bounding is that many elites had strong economic ties to particular geographic areas via their ancestral lands or, in the case of merchants, their business connections.

Figure J1: Trends in MPs with pre-existing surnames by different geographic restrictions on surname connections, 1550-1750



Notes: The English Civil War (1640-49) is shaded in gray, and a gray vertical line at 1688 indicates the Glorious Revolution.

As with all of the name-matching strategies, geographically restricting allowable surname matches involves a tradeoff between Type I (false positive) and Type II (false negative) errors. (Relative to the measurement interpretation above, it also changes what it means for a name to be new to politics.) Restricting last name matches within a small geographic unit, like a constituency, is likely to limit Type I errors, while simultaneously increasing the probability of Type II errors. The reverse is true in allowing surname matches across large spaces—for example, England as a whole, or within nations. Of course, regardless of the geographic bounds, the patrilineal naming conventions in England make connecting dynasties through marriage and the mother’s line far more difficult (absent hyphenated last names). This is acknowledged as an unfortunate but fundamental limitation of the measurement strategy.

I present the national-level plot for dynastic MPs for the different geographic bounds on surname. The plot in Figure J1 demonstrates that there are level differences in these different bounded connections, but little discernible inter-temporal pattern difference that might suggest different groups are systematically missed by a particular geographic bound.

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